

GARBAGE-FREE DELHI,
CM GUPTA'S CIVIC CALL **P3**



INDIA IN CONSTANT TOUCH WITH UKRAINE,
RUSSIA TO END CONFLICT: EAM **P5**

'SHE FINDS HER WAY
TO A COMEBACK' **P12**



275 INDIANS REMAIN MISSING, TOLL RISES TO 1,295

Two workers rescued alive from Nepal tunnel after 9 days of floods

MPOST BUREAU
Kathmandu, September 4

Two men were rescued alive from a tunnel at Nepal's Trishuli 3A hydropower project on Friday following flash floods that have killed at least 1,295 people, left about 5,000 missing and damaged critical infrastructure across northern and central parts of the country. The rescue of mechanical supervisor Kabir Maharjan, 45, and foreman Sanjay Sah, 30, came as security forces continued searches across eight affected districts and authorities began planning relief and recovery measures.

The Nepal Army's Public Relations Directorate identified the two survivors. Maharjan, who is from Kathmandu, was flown to the Nepal Army Hospital



Rescue personnel assist a trapped worker after his rescue from the tunnel of Trishuli 3A Hydropower Project in Rasuwa district, Nepal

in Chhauni, Kathmandu, in critical condition. Sah, from Saptari district in Madhesh province, is being treated at Trishuli Hospital in Nuwakot, according to

Nepal Army spokesperson Raja Ram Basnet.

Sah told security personnel that he spent the nine days trapped inside the tunnel chanting the

"Hare Krishna mahamanttra". He said he had been working in the control room when the disaster struck and stayed behind because he felt responsible

KEY POINTS

- » Survivors were trapped at Trishuli 3A hydropower project
- » Kabir Maharjan, 45, remains in critical condition
- » Sanjay Sah, 30, is receiving hospital treatment
- » Sah chanted Hare Krishna mantra while trapped
- » Sah said he stayed behind to help others escape
- » Rescuers heard voices before establishing tunnel communication

AUTHORITIES ESTIMATE NEARLY 5,000 PEOPLE REMAIN MISSING

for helping others escape. "I was working in the control room. My responsibility was to save everyone's life," Sah said.

CONTINUED ON P4

AFTER CJP PROTEST

Man who bragged about cracking protester's father's skull detained

AIMAN FATIMA & PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
New Delhi, September 4

Delhi Police detained Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj in Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh, on Friday. The action followed hours after Cockroach Janta Party activists staged a demonstration outside the Parliament Street police station, demanding his arrest for assaulting Sanjay Kumar—the father of student protester Nishu Azad. Bhardwaj had previously admitted to the attack and openly bragged about it during a media interview.

Police sources said teams traced Bhardwaj near Dhamra Nara village after following his movements. He had reportedly left Naithla village on a motorcycle during an earlier attempt to apprehend him. He was taken to Chola police station, where he was being questioned about the alleged assault,

CLOSER LOOK

- » The alleged assault occurred during a Jantar Mantar protest
- » Kumar was recording the demonstration when confrontation escalated
- » FIR alleges two-three others joined the assault
- » SC/ST Act provisions were later added to FIR
- » Police are seeking another medical opinion
- » Police will examine the viral podcast recording



- » Bhardwaj allegedly claimed he "cracked" Kumar's skull
- » Bhardwaj claimed political connections with senior leaders
- » Nishu alleged rape threats and verbal abuse

his statements in a viral podcast and his claims of political connections.

The case dates back to a CJP protest against alleged examination paper leaks at Jantar Mantar. According to the FIR, Kumar was recording the demonstration on his mobile phone when a disagreement over filming escalated. The complaint alleged that two-three other men then

joined the confrontation and assaulted him.

Kumar alleged that he was punched on the head and hit with a hard object resembling an iron kada. He was taken to RML Hospital, where doctors recorded two lacerated wounds.

Delhi Police registered a case against Bhardwaj and Suraj Kumar under Sections 115(2), CONTINUED ON P4

Briefs

Zelensky proposes ceasefire

KYIV: Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelensky on Friday proposed a temporary halt to air strikes while US President Donald Trump's envoys Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff travel to Moscow and Kyiv this weekend for talks on ending the Russia-Ukraine war.

Zelensky confirmed on Telegram that Witkoff would visit Moscow on Saturday, followed by

Judicial officers in 7 states to retire at 62

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed seven states to raise the retirement age of judicial officers from 60 to 62 years, citing the need to retain experienced judges and reduce vacancies in the district judiciary.

A bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant, along with Justices Joydalya Bagchi and V Mohana, directed

Centre calls Ladakh leaders for talks

NEW DELHI: The Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has called Ladakh leaders for the next round of talks in New Delhi on September 9, even as the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) prepares a padyatra from Kargil to Leh to press for statehood, Sixth Schedule status and other demands. Ladakh Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra said the meeting is part of the ongoing

PHUKET-DELHI FLIGHT CASE AI sacks pilot following AAIB drug-use finding

NARESH BISWANI
New Delhi, September 4

Air India on Friday terminated with immediate effect the services of the pilot-in-command of its Phuket-Delhi flight after he tested positive for a psychoactive substance following an August 4 incident that injured 24 people.

The airline acted hours after the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) released its preliminary report, which called the confirmed substance use a "serious concern" and recommended that the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) take action to prevent psychoactive substance abuse.

Flight AI 2379, an Airbus A320-251N carrying 137 passengers, including three infants, six cabin crew and two pilots, was cruising at 36,000 feet

AAIB SAID THE CO-PILOT TESTED NEGATIVE FOR PSYCHOACTIVE SUBSTANCES, WHILE THE PILOT-IN-COMMAND'S CONFIRMATORY TEST WAS ALSO NON-NEGATIVE

when all three hydraulic systems lost pressure within seconds. The autopilot disconnected, a brief stall warning followed, and the aircraft gained about 372 feet before losing nearly 292 feet.

The hydraulic systems recovered within seconds and the aircraft continued to Delhi, landing safely at 11 am. Medical teams treated 20 passengers and four crew members. Twenty were discharged after minor injuries, while four were hospitalised with serious injuries. The cabin sustained damage, including cracked

Delhi CEO assures no eligible voter will be excluded

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, September 4

Delhi's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) has assured that no eligible citizen will be excluded from the electoral rolls and no ineligible person will be added, amid concerns over alleged irregularities and the list of "Absent, Shifted, Dead and Duplicate (ASDD)" electors. In a statement issued late Thursday, the CEO's office said booth-level officers (BLOs) identified electors under the ASDD category after conducting door-to-door verification. This included people who could not be located at their registered addresses or were reported to have shifted.

"BLOs completed house-to-house visits after giving due information to BLAs and conducted meetings with them periodically," the statement said.

On concerns that addresses of electors removed

Heavy rain lashes Delhi, airport waterlogged; red alert issued



Heavy rainfall disrupts normal life in northern India

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 4

Delhi on Friday faced its first major spell of September rain, with moderate to heavy showers flooding roads, slowing traffic and disrupting operations at Indira Gandhi International Airport. The India Meteorological Department

(IMD) upgraded the capital's weather warning from yellow to red and forecast more rain and thunderstorms, while neighbouring Noida and Ghaziabad were placed under an orange warning. The downpour came a week before Delhi is scheduled to host the two-day BRICS Summit at

Bharat Mandapam on September 12 and 13.

Palam recorded the highest rainfall in Delhi, receiving 75.6 mm between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm. Lodhi Road recorded 34.6 mm, Safdarjung 32.6 mm, Ridge 20 mm and Ayanagar 12 mm during the same period.

CONTINUED ON P4

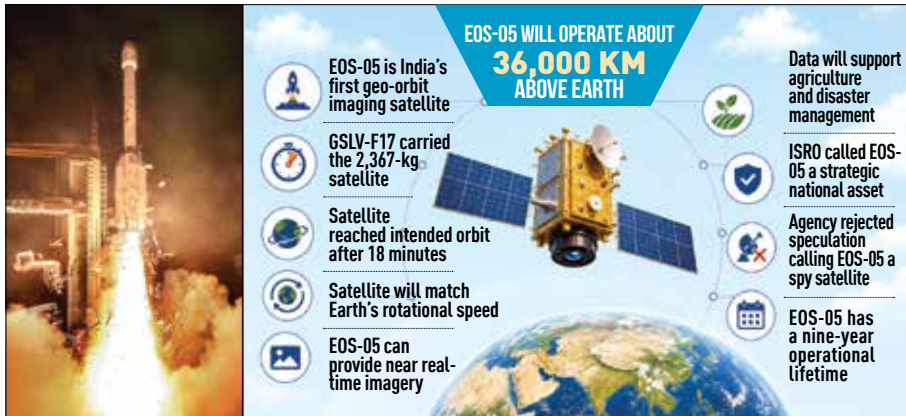
LAUNCH MARKS ISRO'S FIRST SUCCESS OF 2026

'Eye in sky': ISRO launches advanced earth observation satellite for 'strategic data'

MPOST BUREAU
Sriharikota (Andhra Pradesh), September 4

ISRO on Friday successfully launched EOS-05, India's first dedicated imaging satellite designed to operate from geosynchronous orbit, marking the space agency's first successful mission of 2026. The more than 2,300 kg satellite was carried aboard the GSLV-F17 rocket and placed into its intended sub-geosynchronous transfer orbit about 18 minutes after liftoff.

ISRO chief V Narayanan confirmed the mission's success soon after the launch. "I am very happy to announce that the GSLV F-17 vehicle has



successfully and precisely injected the advanced EOS-05 geo imaging satellite in the intended and required orbit," he said.

The launch took place at 2.55 am from the second launch pad at the Satish

Dhawan Space Centre after a 27-hour countdown that began at 11.30 pm on Wednesday. Rain and the pre-dawn timing did not prevent members of the public from gathering at the spaceport, with many using

umbrellas as they watched the rocket rise.

The 51.7-metre, three-stage GSLV has a liftoff mass of 420.5 tonnes and uses a cryogenic third stage. EOS-05, weighing 2,367 kg, is the heaviest

satellite ever launched by a GSLV. Narayanan said the achievement reflected years of improvements to the vehicle, including reductions in structural mass and upgrades to its propulsion systems.

"This is the 107th launch from Sriharikota and the 19th mission of GSLV," Narayanan said. He noted that the first GSLV mission, D1, carried a 1,536 kg payload, compared with the 2,367 kg satellite delivered on Friday.

EOS-05 is expected to provide near real-time imagery for applications such as agriculture and disaster management. Once its orbit-raising operations are

LITTLE GOVINDA



A woman interacts with a child dressed as Lord Krishna during Krishna Janmashtami celebrations PTI

6 nabbed in cyber fraud racket linked to Rs 83 cr

Money trail traced via multiple bank accounts

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

Delhi Police has arrested six people connected to a multi-state cyber fraud racket involved in routing cheated money through multiple bank accounts and shell firms, officials said on Friday.

According to police, with their arrests, including the alleged main handler, police busted a network linked to 89 complaints involving more than Rs 83 crore in fraud, they said.

The accused have been identified as Chetan Sehrawat, Shakti Gurjar, Dharmender Kumar, Tarun, Deepak and Gaurav Kadian.

Acting on an FIR registered at the Dwarka North police station, a suspicious bank account was detected on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal that received cheated money connected to complaints registered in Telangana, Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra.

The investigation revealed that mule accounts were opened on the pretext of providing jobs or salary to unsuspecting people, which were subsequently used to rotate the cheated money.

“Sehrawat was the alleged main handler of



89 COMPLAINTS INVOLVING APPROXIMATELY RS 83.23 CR WERE FOUND LINKED TO THE RACKET, WHILE AN AMOUNT OF RS 1.14 CR WAS PUT ON HOLD THROUGH TIMELY LEGAL ACTION...

the racket, under whom the others worked. The accused opened bank accounts and firms in different names to receive, transfer and withdraw cheated money,” a Delhi Police officer said.

A total of 89 complaints involving approximately Rs 83.23 crore were found linked to the racket, while an amount of Rs 1.14 crore was put on hold through timely legal action.

Sehrawat allegedly fled to Thailand after the registration of the FIR and later moved to Dubai, following which a look-out circular (LOC) was issued against

him. He was arrested from the Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi, the officer said.

Tarun, who also allegedly attempted to flee to Dubai, was held at the Mumbai International Airport with the help of an LOC.

Police seized 12 mobile phones, 109 cheque books, bank account documents, firm registration papers, PAN and other identity documents and cash deposit slips from the accused.

Police are probing a cryptocurrency angle in the case, the officer said.

After ‘assault’ at PS, women journalists to approach HC seeking CCTV footage

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

A day after two women journalists alleged they were assaulted at a south Delhi police station, they said on Friday that they would move the Delhi High Court to demand CCTV footage of the incident.

The journalists, Shaheen Khan and Nafeesa Khan, made the demand at a press conference along with the editor of their digital news channel, Sanjay Sharma, who said he would move to the Delhi High Court on September 7 seeking release of the footage and action against the police personnel.

However, rejecting the allegations, the police said the two women had obstructed a designated VVIP route by parking their scooter near the venue, and despite repeated requests they refused to



comply. Demanding an impartial inquiry into the incident, Sharma said the police personnel found responsible should be “arrested and terminated from service”.

“If there are CCTV cameras in every room of the police station, release the footage. We will accept whatever it shows,” he said.

The journalists alleged that they were detained on Thursday and taken to Saket police station, where they were taken to a room and assaulted. They said they had gone to south Delhi to cover a programme and intended to

“IF THERE ARE CCTV CAMERAS IN EVERY ROOM OF THE POLICE STATION, RELEASE THE FOOTAGE...”

question Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

Khan alleged that the police also asked the journalists about their religious identity and that they were subjected to “discriminatory treatment” after their identity as Muslims became known.

“Our demand is that our illegal detention by Delhi Police and the snatching of our phones be investigated. Even our FIRs have not been registered,” she said.

“This is not just an attack on two journalists. It is an attack on the voice that asks questions, seeks accountability and stands

against what is wrong,” Khan said.

Nafeesa Khan said she had never experienced such treatment because of her religious identity at any school, college or other institution where she had worked.

The allegations could not be independently verified.

Police said, “In view of the security and safety protocol of the VVIP route, both women were taken to the local police station for further enquiry.”

Police also rejected claims that the women were assaulted for attempting to question the chief minister, describing such allegations as “false, misleading and baseless”.

Police statement was deleted, while journalists pursued legal action over alleged assault, detention and religious profiling at Saket police station.

60-year-old man arrested for raping 5-year-old girl

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

A 60-year-old man was arrested for allegedly raping a five-year-old girl who took Arabic lessons from him in the Chakkarpur area of Gurugram, police said on Friday.

Following a complaint filed by the minor’s family, an FIR was registered under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act on Thursday, and the accused was arrested, they added.

According to the police, the family, originally from Bengal, lives in the Chakkarpur area.

In the complaint, the minor’s father stated that his daughter used to go to the neighbouring Bengali man to learn Arabic, and he allegedly molested her during her studies.

The girl returned home and informed her family, who then approached the police. Upon receiving the complaint, the police took the accused into custody.

A senior police officer said that the girl was taken to the Civil Hospital in Sector 10 for a medical examination. Based on medical and preliminary evidence, rape was confirmed, and the accused was arrested, he said. “We are questioning the accused. The Child Welfare Committee is currently counselling the girl”, the officer added.

Teen fatally stabbed; 3 minors apprehended

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

A 15-year-old boy was stabbed to death in Delhi’s Nangloi area allegedly following a dispute over his proximity to a female friend, police said on Friday.

The incident took place on Thursday when the teenager was walking with one of his class-

‘BOY WAS STABBED FOLLOWING A DISPUTE OVER HIS PROXIMITY TO A FEMALE FRIEND’

mates in the Nangloi area, they said.

According to police, four juveniles confronted the boy with whom one of them had an altercation

over his closeness to a female friend of the latter.

During the confrontation, one of the juveniles allegedly stabbed the boy in his right thigh. The attackers then fled the spot, leaving the boy injured.

The victim’s classmate informed his family members about the incident, who took the boy to a nearby hospital

where doctors declared him dead due to excessive blood loss caused by the stab wound, police said.

Police have apprehended three of the juveniles allegedly involved in the attack, and efforts are underway to trace the fourth, officials said.

The body was handed over to the family after a post-mortem on Friday, they said.

Midnight police raid on ex-Delhi Mayor raises questions over inter-state powers

“CROSS-BORDER POLICE ACTION WITHOUT LOCAL COORDINATION OR LEGAL SAFEGUARDS RAISES SERIOUS CONCERNS OVER TRANSPARENCY, ACCOUNTABILITY...”

cers came up completely empty-handed.

The midnight raid later revealed to be tied to an FIR against independent journalist Abhishek Upadhyay, who had reported on the Ram Mandir Trust donation theft highlighted a troubling disregard for legal boundaries. When state lines are crossed in the dark without prior local coordination or statutory paperwork, it lays bare a deep systemic malaise: the culture of institutional opacity, buck-passing, and

a profound reluctance to answer to the public.

The Bureaucratic Maze and the Art of Shuffling Files

When Suri sought accountability the next day, filing formal complaints with the Delhi Police for an FIR, CCTV preservation, and call-record tracing, he did not encounter swift justice. Instead, his grievances became trapped in an administrative labyrinth, bounced between senior echelons like the

Special Commissioner of Police (Law & Order) and the Joint Commissioner of Police (Southern Range).

This systemic ducking of responsibility mirrors the administrative bottlenecks highlighted in public governance and transparency reports, where public authorities frequently fail to respond to online applications, let files gather dust, and avoid disclosures until forced by judicial intervention.

Much like the recurring administrative deficiencies where complaints are shunted across departments without tracking or ownership, it creates an institutionalised method of delaying answers and

dodging responsibility.

The legal battle now resting before the Supreme Court goes far beyond a single nocturnal violation, transforming into a broader crusade for standardised operating procedures. Suri’s petition seeks strict safeguards for inter-state police operations, including prior communication, valid warrants, personnel identification and preservation of electronic records. These measures underscore a broader principle: effective governance requires transparency, clear accountability, defined jurisdictions and oversight, ensuring power remains subject to scrutiny.

Briefs

NDMC sets up 24x7 control room

NEW DELHI: The NDMC will operate a 24x7 Integrated Command & Control Centre from September 5 to 14 to monitor civic services and coordinate with Delhi Police, Traffic Police and other agencies during the BRICS Summit. It will deploy additional sanitation teams, mechanical sweepers, mobile toilets and dustbins, while repairing roads, footpaths and drainage. Special enforcement drives will target encroachments, illegal parking and unauthorised hoardings.

Villagers block road in Narela

NEW DELHI: Villagers blocked a road in Narela on Friday, refusing to cremate property dealer Pramod Dahiya until those responsible for his killing are arrested and punished. Dahiya, a Sonipat resident, was shot dead outside a gym on September 3 after attackers allegedly fired around 15 rounds at him. Police suspect gang rivalry and are examining CCTV footage to identify the assailants and reconstruct the sequence of events. Teams are conducting searches at multiple locations, while police personnel have been deployed amid tension in the area.

Five in cop net as cyber fraud syndicate busted

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

New Delhi, September 4

The Delhi Police Crime Branch has busted an interstate cyber fraud syndicate allegedly involving foreign operators in a fake online investment scheme.

The case was registered through an e-FIR on November 18, 2025, after complainant Gaurav Rustogi was allegedly cheated of Rs 30.06 lakh through WhatsApp groups, Telegram channels and fraudulent investment platforms.

Police arrested Udit Tyagi, 26, of Meerut, after he was apprehended at Jaipur International Airport pursuant to a Look-Out Circular. Investigators

said Tyagi had fled India and travelled to Thailand, Malaysia and the UAE.

The probe found a structured network involving foreign or Chinese operators, Telegram handlers, Indian intermediaries, mule-account providers, cryptocurrency handlers and local coordinators.

Victims were allegedly shown fictitious profits before being persuaded to invest larger amounts, followed by demands for fees to withdraw funds.

Police identified over 18 mule accounts and traced Rs 5 lakh. Four more were arrested, while the network was linked to over 35 cybercrime complaints.

BRICS SUMMIT

Central and south Delhi traffic likely to be hit from Sept 10-14

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

Traffic movement in central, south and southwest Delhi is likely to be affected for four days from September 10 as the national capital prepares to host the two-day BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam on September 12 and 13, officials said on Friday.

Nearly 4,800 traffic personnel have been deployed to manage the movement of foreign delegations and other dignitaries. Restrictions are expected to remain in force from the arrival of foreign delegates on September 10 until their departure around September 14, with diversions,



congestion and temporary road closures likely on several key routes.

According to officials, vehicular movement could be affected on at least 22 arterial roads across central, south and southwest Delhi. Designated routes

will be used by heads of state and foreign delegations, with traffic personnel deployed at strategic points to regulate their movement and regular traffic.

Traffic authorities have raised concerns over the

Cops seek virtual court functioning

New Delhi, September 4

The Delhi Traffic Police has requested virtual functioning of the Patiala House Courts on September 11 due to extensive traffic restrictions around Bharat Mandapam during the BRICS Summit. It also suggested September 12, the second Saturday,

be considered a holiday, subject to approval.

The restrictions could inconvenience judicial officers, lawyers, litigants and court staff.

Traffic officials have also briefed Bar Associations on traffic management and parking arrangements. MPOST

Egyptian delegation staying at a hotel in Saket, where roads are already congested due to infrastructure and repair work.

The delegation’s motorcade between Saket and central Delhi could add pressure to busy south

Delhi stretches, particularly during peak hours. Police have suggested shifting the delegation to central Delhi.

Commuters have been advised to allow extra travel time and monitor traffic advisories.

Gr Noida Authority approves 25 civic projs worth Rs 31.92 crore

DIPIKA KIROLA

Greater Noida, September 4

The Greater Noida Authority has approved 25 development and maintenance projects worth Rs 31.92 crore to improve roads, drainage, street lighting, greenery, parks and other civic infrastructure. Applications have been invited till September 18, with the pre-qualification meeting scheduled for September 21. Work is expected to begin after the process is completed.

Among the major projects, Rs 1.89 crore has been allocated for internal road maintenance in Sector 3, while Rs 1.79 crore will be spent on

resurfacing the Dankaur-Sikandrabad Road towards Dankaur village.

More than Rs 1.57 crore has been earmarked for a pre-stressed RCC drain and green belt along the 80-metre road between Sector 1 and KP-5.

The authority will also spend Rs 1.92 crore on high-mast lights in parks in Omicron-3, Mu-1 and Zeta, and Rs 1.59 crore on streetlights along service roads. Annual maintenance of the Surajpur-Kasna Road, including drain cleaning and kerb repairs, will cost Rs 1.59 crore over three years.

Six projects involving parks and the health department have also been approved.

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Ladakh...

Continued from Page 1

Dialogue on “deepening democratic processes in Ladakh”.

The meeting will include MHA and senior Ladakh administration officials, three representatives each from the Ladakh Apex Body (LAB) and KDA, MP Mohd Hanifa Jan, former MP Thupstan Chhewang, Kargil Hill Council Chairman Mohd Jaffar Akhoon and former Leh Hill Council chief Tashi Gyalson.

It follows meetings in Leh on July 3 and August 19, when regional leaders submitted their “non-negotiable” demands. The LAB has called an emergency meeting to decide whether to attend, as it and the KDA want the High Powered Committee, headed by Union minister Nityanand Rai, to take final decisions.

At the May 22 HPC meeting, an in-principle agreement was reached on a UT-level elected body with legislative, financial and executive powers and seven District Autonomous Councils.

MPOST

CJI KANT HELD DISCUSSIONS WITH JUDICIAL DELEGATIONS

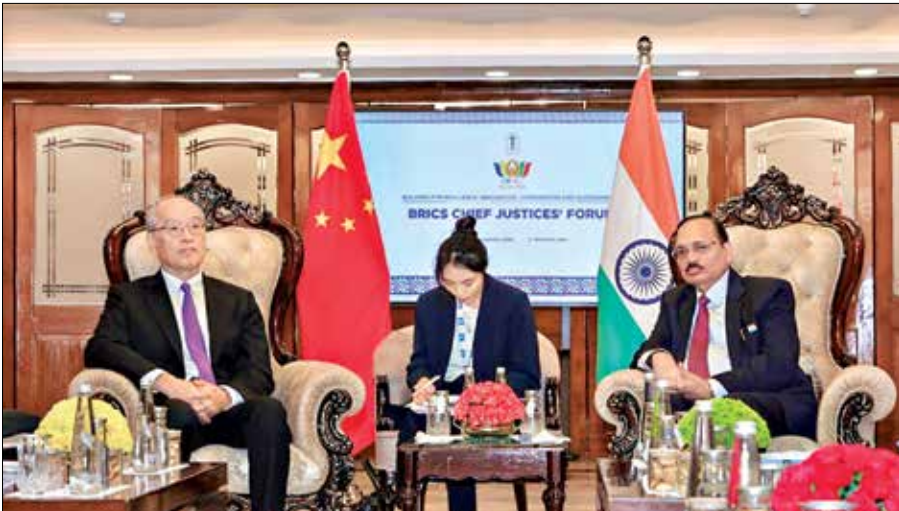
BRICS Chief Justices’ Forum: CJI highlights enhancing bilateral ties

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 4

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Friday highlighted the importance of the role of the judiciary in constructing coordinated bilateral cooperation and enhancing bilateral ties during the BRICS Chief Justices’ Forum.

Speaking at the summit, he also proposed the building of a common platform for arbitration and mediation to tackle commercial disputes.

The Supreme Court on Friday held the BRICS Chief Justices’ Forum here which was attended by chief justices, presidents of supreme courts and senior judicial leaders from BRICS member states and partner



CJI Surya Kant meets President of the Supreme People’s Court of China Zhang Jun during a bilateral meeting, in New Delhi

countries.

As part of the Forum, CJI Kant held a series of bilateral meetings with

heads of judicial delegations on the opening day.

The CJI met judicial leaders from Russia,

China, Egypt, Indonesia, the UAE, Belarus, Kazakhstan, South Africa, Iran and Uzbekistan on the

opening day of the three-day summit.

The bilateral discussions took place around the issues of MoUs for judicial cooperation to strengthen relations between countries, the importance of mediation and arbitration in resolving business and corporate disputes and creating a healthy environment for commercial activities between nations.

The discussions were also held on the requirement of efficient commercial courts to enhance trust of foreign investors, possibilities of mutual recognition of judicial awards and decrees and use of state institutions like the National Judicial Academy, Bhopal, for professional exchange programmes.

J&K: Army kills one terrorist in forest area of Budgam

Operation underway as search continue for a second suspect believed to be holed up in the area

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Srinagar, September 4

A terrorist, believed to be a Pakistani national, was killed on Friday in a high-altitude encounter with the Army and other security forces in central Kashmir’s Budgam district, officials said.

The operation, being conducted by the Indian Army, Jammu and Kashmir Police and CRPF, is underway as security personnel continue to search for a second suspect believed to be holed up in the area.

The officials said the Army launched the operation after tracking movement patterns of a

suspected terror group heading from Ashdar Gali in Poonch towards Pakherpora in Pulwama via Yousmarg in Budgam.

The Army tracked the group’s trajectory across high-altitude mountain passes in the Pir Panjal range, they said.

A cordon was laid in the area on September 1, and contact was established in Ashdar Gali, a remote alpine ridge situated in rugged terrain, on September 3.

Officials said the encounter site is extremely isolated, requiring troops to trek nearly 10 hours from the Doodhpathri area to reach the location.

From page 1

Nepal tunnel

He said he urged others to flee, but could not get out himself after they had left.

Sah said he had been able to hear or communicate with three or four people nearby, but believed others could still be trapped deeper inside the long tunnel, including near the powerhouse. The rescue operation intensified after security personnel heard voices from inside and established communication with people believed to be trapped.

Maharjan’s wife, Hira Shobha, described his survival as a “second life” and thanked the rescuers. “We had been waiting. I am now going to the hospital to see my husband,” she said, adding that the family had struggled to eat or sleep during the nine-day wait.

The wider search continued as Nepal Police reported 1,293 bodies recovered from eight districts. Chitwan accounted for 359, followed by Nawalparasi East with 221, Nawalparasi West with 212, Nuwakot with 186, Rasuwa with 140, Gorkha with 72, Dhading with 65 and Tanahu with 38.

Two other victims died in hospitals in Kathmandu on Friday, taking the overall toll to 1,295. Authorities said 13,093 people had been rescued.

The disaster has also left hundreds of children unaccounted for. Preliminary figures indicate about 280 children are missing in Rasuwa and 300 to 350 in Nuwakot. Bidur Municipality alone has reported around 250 missing children. At least 22 teachers and school staff are also missing in the two districts, including 16 from Rasuwa and six from Nuwakot.

Several teachers from Dhading and Gorkha who had travelled to Rasuwa for pilgrimage were caught in the floods.

The Ministry of Education said 22 schools in Rasuwa, Nuwakot and Dhading were affected, with 12 completely destroyed. The Independent Power Producers’ Association of Nepal said more than 600 people working at 11 hydropower projects remained missing.

The floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, also damaged 35 motorable bridges, 45 suspension bridges and 40 km of black-topped roads, mainly in central Nepal.

India has continued its assistance to the relief effort. External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said 275 Indians remained missing and 166 had been rescued. Another 1,907 Indian nationals safely crossed into Nepal from China, while Chinese authorities reported no Indian travellers stranded in the Tibetan Autonomous Region.

India has sent about 95 tonnes of relief material on seven aircraft, including forensic kits and medical supplies, and

deployed 54 personnel comprising 30 tunnel rescue experts, 19 forensic experts and a five-member medical team. Jaiswal said more forensic kits, Bailey bridges and other requested supplies would be sent.

The latest assistance included 21.5 tonnes of material carried by the sixth and seventh Indian relief flights, which arrived in Kathmandu on Thursday night.

Man who bragged

126(2) and 3(5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. Police have rejected subsequent claims that Kumar suffered a skull fracture, saying his medical examination described the injuries as simple and did not establish a fracture.

The case gained fresh attention after a podcast clip featuring Bhardwaj went viral. In the interview, Bhardwaj, who describes himself as a “kattar” (staunch) Hindu, claimed that he cracked the skull of Nishu’s father and got away with it.

“I cracked the skull of Nishu’s father. Do you know which section this crime attracts? Section 307. He needed 60 stitches. The man was being taken away in an ambulance in a serious condition. His daughter was standing outside the police station and saying that she would die by suicide if her father didn’t get justice. But I was not even jailed. The world should know this. I was out and about through the night,” Bhardwaj said in the interview.

Bhardwaj further claimed to have political connections, naming BJP leader Kapil Mishra and Union Minister Chirag Paswan.

“I have the blessings of Hanuman upon me. And secondly, Kapil Mishra is my elder brother. They say Kapil Mishra called and I was released. Chirag Paswan is my elder brother. How many leaders do you know? Do you know Modi ji? Modi ji is also my elder brother. I have everyone’s support,” he said.

Paswan has since approached the police, alleging that Bhardwaj misused his name.

The remarks triggered demands from the CJP and Opposition parties for immediate action. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi questioned why Bhardwaj was not in jail and alleged that he was receiving political protection. Delhi Police has denied political interference and maintained that the case was being investigated according to legal procedure.

The detention came hours after the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) staged a protest outside the Parliament Street police station, demanding immediate arrest of Bhardwaj and stronger action in the case.

CJP co-conveners Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, along with party supporters, Congress representatives, Azad Samaj Party MP Chandrashekhra Azad and independent MP Pappu Yadav, joined the demonstration and

met police officials.

The delegation sought invocation of an attempt-to-murder provision and provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, pointing out that Kumar belongs to a Scheduled Caste. Police subsequently added provisions of the SC/ST Act to the FIR.

Police are also seeking a further medical opinion before deciding whether the attempt-to-murder charge is warranted. The viral podcast recording will also be examined as part of the investigation.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke accused Delhi Police of shielding the accused and called for DCP Sachin Sharma’s prosecution, alleging that Nishu Aazad had “begged” police to arrest those responsible for assaulting her father, but that they continued to remain free even two months after the incident.

Congress leader Abhishek Singhvi said police had assured the delegation that Bhardwaj would be arrested within 72 hours. The assurance also covered action over alleged online threats against Nishu.

Bhardwaj has since denied deliberately attacking Kumar and offered a different account of the incident. He claimed he was surrounded by 10-12 people and acted to protect himself.

“I did not attack him deliberately. I was scared that I might be mob-lynched, so I acted in self-defence.”

He claimed he had video evidence showing people cornering him and said he struck Kumar with his kada only after standing up in self-defence. He also disputed the severity of Kumar’s injuries, citing the medical report.

Bhardwaj has called the viral podcast clip “fake” and denied receiving political protection. In another interview, however, he reportedly said that if faced with a similar situation again, he would use his kada once more.

Nishu has separately alleged that she faced verbal abuse and rape threats after pursuing the assault case and said the incident affected her ability to attend school.

“I was ashamed of even stepping out. For a few weeks I could not go to school. I feel everyone is judging me. I hope police will take action,” she said.

She welcomed the police assurance of action, saying, “We believe they will take action and not keep delaying it as they were doing.”

AI sacks

ceiling panels, broken handrails and dislodged overhead bins.

AAIB said the co-pilot tested negative for psychoactive substances, while the pilot-in-command’s confirmatory test was also non-negative. The report did not establish any link between the drug result and the hydraulic failure or altitude upset.

Investigators are examin-

ing technical and operational factors, including the aircraft’s maintenance history and a Power Transfer Unit-related MEL item invoked on July 28. Flight recorders and hydraulic components have been recovered for further analysis.

Air India said it has begun voluntary drug testing of all its pilots and continues to cooperate with investigators.

Delhi CEO

from the rolls were not listed, the office said booth-level agents (BLAs) appointed by political parties were expected to record the addresses of ASDD electors from BLOs during these meetings.

The draft electoral roll was shared with recognised political parties on August 31. Citizens and party representatives can check the rolls at Electoral Registration Officer and Assistant ERO offices, through BLOs and at designated polling stations.

Those who missed the June 30 to August 17 submission window can still apply. The CEO said they may submit Form 6 and the prescribed Declaration Form between August 31 and September 30, 2026, during the claims and objections period.

Heavy rain

Earlier, the airport experienced a brief two-minute squall that brought 7 mm of rain, with winds reaching 76 kmph and visibility falling to 600 metres.

Waterlogging was reported at several locations, including

Vasant Kunj, Mahipalpur, Mehrauli, Connaught Place, Maulana Azad Road, Akbar Road, Kali Bari Marg, Basant Gaon and Sub-rocket Park. The Pul Prahladpur, Zakhira and Minto Bridge underpasses were also affected, along with areas around Utsav Park in Patparganj, Sadar Bazar, Kamla Nagar, ITO and Mathura Road. The airport-Vasant Kunj underpass was completely flooded.

At the airport, water accumulated around Terminal 3, its underpass and approach roads, forcing passengers and commuters to wade through water with luggage. Nine flights were diverted between 3.30 pm and 4.30 pm, with four each sent to Jaipur and Lucknow and one to Ahmedabad. Air India warned passengers that bad weather could affect flights to and from Delhi, while IndiGo said adverse weather had affected domestic schedules and that it was monitoring conditions.

The flooding also affected the Dwarka underpass, which connects the Palam area with the domestic airport and falls under the Public Works Department (PWD). A PWD official said temporary pumps were deployed and the water was later cleared. A Delhi Transport Corporation bus was briefly stranded there, while other buses on the route were diverted.

The official said PWD teams are required to alert the control room when water stagnation in an underpass reaches 6

to 8 inches and deploy mobile pumps. If water continues rising, the control room informs the Traffic Police to stop vehicles and alerts DTC to divert buses.

Another underpass connecting Mahipalpur, Mehrauli and Vasant Kunj was flooded. Officials said several other roads and underpasses around the airport are maintained by the Delhi International Airport Limited (DIAL) and the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), rather than the PWD.

The disruption raised questions about coordination among agencies ahead of the BRICS Summit. On August 26, Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu held a meeting with departments and agencies on waterlogging and called for a “whole of government” approach. He had also directed the PWD and other agencies to submit reports on waterlogging-related problems by the end of August.

Traffic was heavy across the capital. A tree fell near the Gitanjali red light on the Malviya Nagar-Badarpur stretch, blocking traffic. The Delhi Traffic Police advised commuters to avoid the route and use MB Road instead.

Despite the widespread waterlogging, the MCD received only one complaint between 3 pm and 6 pm, from the south-west zone. The NDMC received one waterlogging complaint and four power outage complaints. Delhi’s AQI remained in the ‘satisfactory’ category at 71.

The rain was part of a wider spell across northern India. In Gurugram, Cyber City, Shankar Chowk and Sheela Mata Road were waterlogged.

Uttar Pradesh, where about 3.53 lakh people in 26 districts are affected by floods, also recorded rain, with Sultanpur receiving 16.4 mm, Gorakhpur 10.4 mm, Aligarh 9.4 mm and Shahjahanpur 8.6 mm.

More rain and thunderstorms are forecast, with western Uttar Pradesh expected to receive more widespread activity than the east.

The state has deployed 1,634 flood outposts, 1,697 boats and motorboats, 1,068 medical teams and 1,312 flood shelters. The Ganga was above the danger level in Varanasi, while the Ghaghra was also flowing above the danger level in Ballia.

Himachal Pradesh reported 102 road closures, including 46 in Mandi, 22 in Kullu, 11 in Sirmour and eight in Kangra. Punjab and Haryana received moderate rain, while Rajasthan saw heavy to very heavy rain at isolated places, with Khandar in Sawai Madhopur recording 130 mm in the 24 hours to Friday morning.

Bihar also faced flood-like conditions in several districts as the Ganga, Gandak, Kosi, Burhi Gandak, Bagmati, Punpun and Ghaghra rose following heavy rain in Nepal and Jharkhand.

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary reviewed relief operations

after an aerial survey. Officials said no casualties had been reported and people living in river floodplains had been moved to safer areas.

Sonia Gandhi

representatives over “a particular issue”. The publisher said there was “no external pressure whatsoever” and declined to disclose details, citing confidentiality.

The dispute had triggered allegations from Congress leaders that pressure was being applied to remove references to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the RSS and China’s occupation of Indian territory during the Modi government.

The memoir traces Gandhi’s childhood in post-war Veneto, Italy, her meeting with Rajiv Gandhi in Cambridge in 1965, and her adjustment to life in India. It also recounts the deaths of Sanjay Gandhi, Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi, and her decision to decline the prime minister’s post after the Congress-led alliance won the 2004 election.

Reacting to the announcement, Congress leader Pawan Khera said on X, “No matter how much a Penguin tries, it can’t fly.”

ISRO

completed, it will be positioned at about 36,000 km above Earth, where it will travel at the same rotational speed as the planet. ISRO said the satellite is planned to provide strategic data for national activities.

Mission Director Thomas Kurien described the spacecraft as uniquely configured for near real-time imaging and said it was the heaviest satellite GSLV had placed into a geosynchronous transfer or sub-transfer orbit. Project Director Imteyaz Ahamed called EOS-05 a complex satellite with multi-band capabilities.

Narayanan said the satellite’s systems were functioning normally and that its solar panel had been deployed successfully. The spacecraft has an operational lifetime of nine years.

ISRO also rejected speculation that EOS-05 was a “spy satellite”. The mission is regarded as a replacement for the GSLV-F10/EOS-03 mission, which failed in 2021 after an onboard computer halted the flight 307 seconds after liftoff. An investigation found an anomaly in the cryogenic upper stage.

Friday’s success came nearly eight months after the previous launch.

On January 12, the PSLV-C62 mission, carrying 16 satellites, failed to place its payloads in the intended orbit following an anomaly in its third stage.

The latest achievement drew messages of congratulations from political leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and several chief ministers.

Modi described the launch as “a proud moment for our nation”, while Shah said India now has its first imaging satellite operating from geosynchronous orbit.

Zelensky

Kushner’s visit to Kyiv on Sunday. The trips, also confirmed by a US official, will mark their first visit to the Ukrainian capital for negotiations on a settlement.

“We discussed today that Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner will visit Moscow and on Sunday they will visit Kyiv,” Zelensky said.

He proposed that Ukraine suspend air strikes for the duration needed to hold the talks and resolve logistical arrangements, calling on Russia to “mirror this” by maintaining the same pause.

The proposal came hours after Russia launched a midday strike on the headquarters of Ukraine’s intelligence service in Kyiv. Zelensky said the attack targeted the intelligence chief’s office.

Russia has also stepped up daytime strikes on Kyiv and other cities. An overnight attack in Odesa killed one person and injured at least five, including a child, while two police officials were killed in Dnipro.

Zelensky said Ukraine wants “real options” to end the war, which has continued for four-and-a-half years.

Judicial

Chhattisgarh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Sikkim, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal to amend their service rules, preferably within two months.

The extension will be subject to an assessment of an officer’s suitability by the concerned High Court at 60.

Until the rules are amended, judicial officers who reach 60 in these states will not retire, subject to assessment of their suitability and performance.

The court also said officers who retired on or after March 31 this year may opt to return to judicial service if they have not taken up another job.

The bench asked 23 states and Union Territories, including Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Gujarat, Kerala, Rajasthan, Telangana, Delhi, Jammu and Kashmir and Puducherry, to reconsider their decisions on raising the retirement age and submit compliance reports within two weeks.

The court said retaining experienced officers could narrow the gap between sanctioned and working strength and improve access to justice. It also backed High Court assessments to remove unsuitable officers while retaining competent judges.

The retirement age is 65 for Supreme Court judges and 62 for High Court judges. The issue follows a 2002 decision rejecting a recommendation to raise the district judiciary’s retirement age to 62.

Briefs

‘Disasters know no borders’

MUMBAI: The Congress’s Seva Dal has been engaged in relief-material distribution and rehabilitation work across the flood-hit states of the country as well as in neighbouring Nepal, with its chief, Srinivas B V, stressing that disasters know no borders.

Seva Dal relief teams are carrying out operations in flood-hit areas, according to a statement issued by the organisation.

Anna Hazare recovering

MUMBAI: Social activist Anna Hazare, who was admitted to a Mumbai hospital earlier this week with a renal infection, is recovering well and his creatinine levels have improved, his close aide said on Friday.

The 89-year-old is expected to be discharged from Bombay Hospital in the next two to three days, he said.

Shah meets Tripura CM

AGARTALA: With elections to 587 village committees of TTA-ADC scheduled for September 28, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday held a meeting with Tripura Chief Minister Manik Saha and TMP founder Pradyot Kishore Manikya Debbarma in New Delhi, according to a social media post by the CM.

“Met Union Home minister Amit Shah in New Delhi today. During the meeting, founder of Tipra Motha Party (TMP) Maharaja Pradyot Kishore Manikya Debbarma and BJP North East Coordinator Dr Sambit Patra were also present,” Saha wrote on Facebook.

‘Collective efforts need to restore trust’

IMPHAL: Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Friday called for collective efforts to bridge the trust deficit among communities and create a peaceful environment for the younger generation.

Singh made the remarks during a visit to L Champhai village in Kangpokpi district to inspect a water supply project.

He urged the village chairman to extend full cooperation to government officials to facilitate the smooth discharge of their duties.

Man kills teen wife, dies by suicide

MUMBAI: A 19-year-old daily-wage labourer allegedly murdered his teenage wife before dying by suicide following a domestic dispute in central Mumbai’s Agripada in the early hours of Friday, police said.

Mohammad Ehsan Sheikh got into an argument with his wife Jannat and allegedly slit her throat before turning the weapon on himself, he said.

‘INDIA WARNED US’

Belgium PM sounds alarm over trade threat to Europe

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever said Europe had undergone a “rude awakening” over the risks posed by trade and industrial dependencies, acknowledging that India had warned European nations about the issue earlier but that the warning was not heeded.

Speaking about the prospects of a deeper India-Europe strategic partnership at a CII event, De Wever said the two sides face similar challenges, particularly as economic dependencies are increasingly being used as leverage.

“We face the same challenges. We are confronted with the same power blocks that are going in a certain direction, a direction that we maybe do not like and we do not like to be pushed around. We do not like dependencies becoming weaponised against us,” he said.

The Belgian prime minister then pointed to India’s earlier warnings to Europe.

“Your prime minister warned Europe about this long time ago already, but he was ignored. He wasn’t listened to. We are listening now. It’s a bit late maybe in Europe this awakening, but it is happening,” De Wever said.

He was responding to



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a meeting with his Belgian counterpart Bart De Wever, in New Delhi

PTI

KEY POINTS

- » De Wever said Europe was now actively looking for partners that continued to believe in multilateralism and cooperation based on ‘respect and not force’
- » Belgian PM described India as the world’s largest and fastest-growing economy, with a large pool of talent and significant scope for future cooperation

a question on why Europe and India could build a durable strategic partnership at a time when the global economy is fragmenting, and why India should choose Europe as a long-term partner for trade, investment, technology and supply-chain resilience.

De Wever said Europe was now actively looking for partners that continued

to believe in multilateralism and cooperation based on ‘respect and not force.’

“With who in the world with which large economies in the world can we develop that kind of a relationship well if India is not on the list on that list then you have missed something very fundamental. India is on that list. It’s number one,” he said.

He described India as

Jarange continues fast, slams Bhujbal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Jalna, September 4

GSLV rocket.

Friday’s launch marked the space agency’s maiden success for the year 2026.

In a post on X, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said, “Congratulations to the entire @isro team on the successful GSLV-F17/EOS-05 mission! EOS-05, India’s first imaging satellite, from Geosynchronous orbit, will further strengthen our Earth Observation capabilities that we have been developing for years.”

“We are immensely proud of our scientists, space engineers and researchers whose dedication and ingenuity continue to take India’s space programme to greater heights,” the Congress chief said.

The Congress party has always remained deeply committed to scientific temper and space research, he said.

The activist, who has undertaken several fasts for the reservation demand so far, also targeted senior OBC leader and Maharashtra minister Chhagan Bhujbal who has been opposing the grant of reservation to the Marathas from the Other Backward Class quota.

Maratha reservation activist Manoj Jarange on Friday refused to call off his hunger strike, which entered the seventh day, until his demands about allotment of Kunbi caste certificates were fulfilled.

Speaking to reporters at Antarwali Sarati village in the district, he demanded a Government Resolution (GR) by September 12 regarding the issuance of Kunbi certificates to eligible Marathas. A meeting of the Maratha community would be held in the village on September 12, he said.

The activist, who has undertaken several fasts for the reservation demand so far, also targeted senior OBC leader and Maharashtra minister Chhagan Bhujbal who has been opposing the grant of reservation to the Marathas from the Other Backward Class quota.

the world’s largest and fastest-growing economy, with a large pool of talent and significant scope for future cooperation. He contrasted this with more mature economies such as Japan, saying India offered substantial opportunities for mutually beneficial growth.

Earlier in his address, De Wever said Europe’s recent experience with trade and industrial dependencies had been a “rude awakening.” “For too long, Europe looked on as over-capacity was dumped below cost on our market, as its industrial base was undermined, and as dependencies were deliberately built up so that they could be used as leverage,” he said.

‘Tribal students’ fight not just for education but for Adivasi identity’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday said the fight of tribal students from Maharashtra is not just for education, employment, hostels, and food but it is also for their existence and Adivasi identity.

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha shared on X a video of his interaction with tribal students on Wednesday during his visit to Nashik.

In a post in Hindi on X accompanying the video, Gandhi said, “We are Adivasis; RSS-BJP want to turn us into Vanasis”. The fight of tribal students from Nashik and Maharashtra is not just for education, employment, hostels, and food—it’s also for their existence and Adivasi identity.”

It was a pleasure to meet these brave students, who stood firm against the Maharashtra government, raised their voice for their

‘India in constant touch with Ukraine, Russia to end conflict’

Jaishankar held talks with Ukrainian leaders on Thursday

AGENCIES

Warsaw, September 4

India has been in continuous touch with both the Ukrainian and Russian sides and is trying to see if there are ideas and suggestions which can be developed in some way that will contribute to the mitigation or the cessation of the conflict, External Affairs minister S Jaishankar said on Friday.

Jaishankar, who arrived in Warsaw from Kyiv where he held talks with top Ukrainian leadership on Thursday, made the remarks after he met Poland’s Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Radoslaw Sikorski.

Addressing a joint press meet alongside Sikorski, Jaishankar said that he discussed the complex global challenges, including supply chain resilience and food, fuel and fertiliser



EAM S Jaishankar meets with members of the Poland-India Parliamentary Group, in Warsaw

PTI

security, with his Polish counterpart.

“The Deputy Prime Minister and I also understandably discussed some major global and regional issues, notable among them is the war in Ukraine, now in its fifth year... I myself have just come here from Kyiv,” he said, referring to his visit to Ukraine a day earlier.

Replying to a question, he said India has been in continuous touch with both the Ukrainian and

Russian sides.

“What we are trying to do is to see if there are ideas and suggestions which can be developed in some way in which they will contribute to the mitigation, ideally, the cessation of the conflict,” he added.

A day earlier, Jaishankar had said in Ukraine that India is ready to extend “any help in any manner” to end the Ukraine-Russia war.

UP polls: Cong discusses to strengthen party

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

Ahead of next year’s Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, the Congress intensified efforts to revamp its state unit, with new office-bearers likely to be appointed at all organisational levels later this month.

AICC General Secretary (Organisation) K C Venugopal held deliberations on Thursday and Friday with state in-charge Rajendra

Pal Gautam, state Congress chief Ajay Rai, Congress Legislature Party leader in UP Assembly Aradhana Mishra ‘Mona’, and co-in-charge secretaries regarding organisational changes and the appointment of new district presidents.

In a post on X, Venugopal said over the past two days, he has held detailed discussions with UP leaders regarding the selection of new district presidents.

He said that in view of the 2027 Assembly

elections, the Congress is preparing for sweeping changes to further strengthen the Opposition in Uttar Pradesh.

“In the run up to the upcoming Assembly Elections, we are gearing up to revamp our organisation to further consolidate the Opposition’s position in UP. As was seen in 2024, the people of UP have decided to throw out the BJP and the Congress will play a critical role in ensuring their defeat,” he said in his post.

UP: SP turns school mergers into political issue ahead of Teachers’ Day

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

Lucknow, September 4



Congress MP Rahul Gandhi interacts with a delegation of tribal students, in Nashik, Maharashtra

PTI

rights, and achieved victory, Gandhi said.

“Promised the students—we, the Congress, and I stand with them in every fight for their rights,” he said.

Gandhi had met the delegation of tribal students, including those who were on a hunger strike to press for their demands, during his visit to Nashik in Maharashtra on Wednesday.

The students were protesting over a range of issues, including the condition of ashram schools

meant for tribals.

Gandhi, in a post on X on Wednesday, had said, “Education is not a privilege -- it is the right of every student in India.”

The Congress leader had said that during his Nashik visit, he met with a delegation of tribal students and carefully listened to their problems and demands.

Every student has the right to a respectful, safe, and conducive environment for their studies, the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha had said.

The Samajwadi Party (SP) has turned the issue of school mergers in Uttar Pradesh into a political flashpoint ahead of Teachers’ Day, accusing the BJP government of shutting down thousands of government schools in rural areas in the name of consolidation.

The party has launched a campaign under the banner ‘Pathshala Pukare’ and directed its workers to hold programmes outside schools that it claims have been closed or merged.

The campaign is aimed at using Teachers’ Day on September 5 to highlight what the Opposition describes as a “decade-long assault on rural education”.

SP state president Shyam Lal Pal had issued directives on August 31 asking party workers, including members of the Chhatra Sabha and Shikshak Sabha, to organise Teachers’ Day programmes near the sites of alleged school closures.

The campaign has already begun in Siddharthnagar, where SP workers organised a programme in Mohankoli village in the Shohratgarh constituency.

Study kits were distributed among children whose local schools, according to the party, are no longer functioning.

SP Shikshak Sabha vice-president Marinder Mishra said the campaign was being carried out following instructions from party president Akhilesh Yadav to keep the focus on children in villages affected by the school mergers.

SUBMITTING FINAL REPORT

SC-appointed Aravalli panel seeks 6-month extension

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

The Supreme Court-appointed Aravalli High-Powered Committee (HPC) has asked the apex court to extend the deadline for submission of its final report by six months, saying it needs more time for a “comprehensive and defensible” assessment of the Aravalli range.

In its compliance report submitted on August 31, the committee has said it needs to bring together spatial, ecological, geological, hydrological, socio-

economic, and stakeholder evidence before arriving at its conclusions regarding the Aravallis.

The committee, constituted through an order dated May 25, has been conducting an independent review of the Centre’s report on the definition and delineation of the Aravallis. The deadline for the panel’s final report was August 31.

“The committee has... reached the view that additional time is necessary to complete the scientific process of geospatial assessment, sensitivity

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The committee, constituted through an order dated May 25, has been conducting an independent review of the Centre’s report on the definition and delineation of the Aravallis
- » In its compliance report, the panel says the issues regarding Aravallis extend beyond technical delineation

analysis, expert examination, field and stakeholder validation, and synthesis required for a comprehensive and defensible report,” said the panel in its compliance report. It has urged the top court to extend the deadline for

submission of the final report to February 28, 2027.

In its compliance report, the panel says the issues regarding Aravallis extend beyond technical delineation and cannot be properly addressed

through a “single terrain-based criterion or a single source of evidence”.

That is why an examination “of the wider geological, geomorphological, hydrological, biogeographical, ecological, biodiversity, mineral-resource and socio-economic dimensions of the Aravalli” is required.

This proposed method -- called the Aravalli Ecosystem Landscape (AEL) framework -- could help identify areas with differing socio-ecological characteristics and inform differentiated approaches

to conservation and management, the panel has said. The framework could also “assess the adequacy of the existing regulatory framework in addressing such areas”.

The committee has suggested that the framework be subject to review and feedback by domain experts and concerned stakeholders.

Notably, the panel conducted its field visits for first-hand assessment of the Aravallis between August 6 and August 11, during which public hearings also took place.

PAVES WAY FOR NAUTOR LAND PROPRIETARY RIGHTS

Ladakh L-G approves new nautor regularisation rules

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Leh, September 4

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Friday approved the regularisation rules of ‘nautor lands’, paving the way for the grant of proprietary rights over eligible barren land and resolving a long-pending issue concerning thousands of landholders in the Union territory.

Nautor land refers to barren or wasteland owned by the government and historically allotted to individuals for cultivation or other productive purposes. More than 60,000 acres of land in Ladakh is presently recorded in revenue records as nautor holdings.

The new rules in Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (Nautor Regularisation) Rules, 2026, provide a comprehensive framework for granting proprietary rights over up to 10 acres of eligible nautor land to occupants across all seven districts of Ladakh, an official spokesperson said.

Nautor land beyond the 10-acre limit may be allotted on a leasehold basis in accordance with the rules.

“The rules introduce a one-time regularisation mechanism for nautor land occupied before October 27, 2020, the date on which the JK tenancy act, 1980 was repealed. Any posses-



sion of such land after the cut-off date will not be eligible for regularisation”, he said. The new framework also vests the authority to allot nautor land with the LAHDCs in all seven districts. “Under Section 42 of the Ladakh autonomous hill development councils act, 1997, land within the district stands transferred to the Council, while clause (i) of Section 23 vests executive powers in the Council in relation to the allotment, use and occupation of land vested in it,” the rules state.

Saxena said the rules seek to strike a balance between protecting the legitimate interests of genuine nautor landholders and safeguarding public and Council land from encroachment and unauthorised claims.

“The nautor issue has a deep historical connection with the lives and livelihoods of the people of

Ladakh. For generations, our people have worked hard to bring barren and waste land under cultivation in one of the most challenging agricultural environments in the country,” the lieutenant governor said.

“These rules provide a transparent and uniform mechanism to address this long-pending issue and give legal certainty to genuine holders. It will also enable such land to be utilised as a financial asset, including for availing bank loans,” he added.

The spokesperson said the absence of a clear and uniform legal framework had restricted effective utilisation of nautor land, particularly for holders who did not possess proprietary rights and were consequently unable to use the land as a financial asset, including for obtaining loans. The new framework is also aimed

KEY POINTS

» Nautor refers to govt-owned barren land, historically allotted to individuals for productive purposes

» More than 60,000 acres of land in Ladakh is presently recorded in revenue records as nautor holdings

at preventing disputes and unauthorised claims over government and council land, he added.

Under the rules, genuinely eligible nautor holders can be granted proprietary rights up to 10 acres, with the amount payable for proprietary rights fixed at the market rate notified by the administration for the concerned revenue village, he added.

For nautor holdings beyond 10 acres, proprietary rights may be allotted on a leasehold basis, with the premium fixed at 80 per cent of the notified market rate.

For ‘Gair Mustaqil’ holdings, field verification by revenue authorities will be mandatory to establish the identity of the occupant, area under occupation, nature and extent of cultivation, date of possession, and whether the occupation existed before the prescribed cut-off date.

AUG 4 INCIDENT: PILOT FAILS DOPE TEST

Air India Phuket-Delhi flight lost all 3 hydraulic systems at 36K feet: AAIB

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 4

An Air India Airbus A320 carrying 145 people suffered the near-simultaneous loss of all three hydraulic systems while cruising at 36,000 feet on a Phuket-Delhi flight on August 4, triggering an autopilot disconnect, a brief stall warning and an altitude upset that left 24 people injured, according to a preliminary report by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB).

The report said the aircraft’s green hydraulic system lost pressure at 04:02:43 UTC, followed four seconds later by the detection of pressure loss in the blue and yellow systems. The hydraulic systems recovered within seconds and the aircraft continued to Delhi, where it landed safely.

During the episode, the aircraft climbed about 372 feet above its assigned altitude and subsequently

THE HYDRAULIC SYSTEMS RECOVERED WITHIN SECONDS AND THE AIRCRAFT CONTINUED TO DELHI, WHERE IT LANDED SAFELY

descended around 292 feet below Flight Level 360. The autopilot disconnected and a stall warning sounded for about two seconds before the co-pilot initially regained control. The pilot-in-command (PIC) then took over.

The incident occurred with seat-belt signs switched off, leaving passengers and crew vulnerable to the sudden movement. Twenty passengers and four cabin crew members were treated at hospitals. Twenty were discharged after treatment for minor injuries, while four people with serious injuries were admitted.

The aircraft suffered extensive cabin damage, including cracked ceiling panels, dislodged overhead-bin doors, broken handrails, damaged passenger-service-unit panels, a broken emergency-exit handle and damage to a crew seat.

The report also disclosed that the PIC tested non-negative for a psychoactive substance after landing. His initial test was followed by a confirmatory blood test that also returned a non-negative result. The co-pilot tested negative. AAIB recommended that the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) take action to prevent abuse of psychoactive substances.

However, the report did not establish any link between the PIC’s test result and the hydraulic failure or altitude upset. Hours after the report was released, Air India terminated the PIC’s services with immediate effect.

Flight AI-2379, operated by an Airbus A320-251N registered VT-EXO, had departed Phuket at 01:41 UTC with 137 passengers, six cabin crew and two pilots. The aircraft landed at Delhi at 05:30 UTC.

Investigators are examining the aircraft’s maintenance history, including a recurring Power Transfer Unit issue recorded under the Minimum Equipment List on July 28. Hydraulic components and fluid samples have been sent for testing, while Cockpit Voice Recorder and Flight Data Recorder information has been downloaded.

Experts from France’s BEA and Airbus inspected the aircraft between August 13 and 15. AAIB is also examining operational, maintenance, weather and air traffic control data.

The report is preliminary and subject to change. A final report will be issued after the investigation is completed.

CBI arrests 3 in Rs 42-cr ‘digital arrest fraud’ cases

NARESH BISWANI
New Delhi, September 4

The CBI, under Operation Chakra-VI, conducted searches at 89 locations across 20 states and arrested three people in connection with three digital arrest fraud cases involving over Rs 42 crore.

The agency took over cases registered by Rajasthan, Gujarat and Karnataka Police, in which fraudsters allegedly posed as police personnel and digitally detained victims before cheating them of crores. In Rajasthan, a BITS Pilani student was allegedly kept under digital arrest for nearly three months and cheated of Rs 7.67 crore. A Gujarat victim was defrauded of Rs 19.24 crore over three months, while a Karnataka victim allegedly lost Rs 15.45 crore after being digitally detained for a month.

Searches were conducted after analysing financial transactions and account-access details. The arrested accused allegedly helped receive, layer and transfer the fraudulently obtained funds. Haryana’s Akash “received Rs 1.95 crore, while Kolkata-based Raja Karmakar received Rs 1.50 crore in his company’s account. The role of Jyoti Rani, who withdrew and transferred funds, is under investigation”.

MP’s maternal & newborn care models draw national attention

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA
Bhopal, September 4

Two Madhya Pradesh initiatives aimed at improving maternal and newborn healthcare—Suman Panchayat and Suman Sakhi, an AI-powered chatbot—have been recognised as best practices and scalable interventions at the national level, opening the possibility of their adoption by other states.

The initiatives were showcased at the National Workshop on SUMAN Roadmap 2030, held in Lucknow on September 2 and 3, where representatives from several states were briefed on their implementation and potential for replication.

The workshop also highlighted Anmol 2.0, a dashboard used to identify and track high-risk pregnant women and facilitate timely follow-up, referrals and institutional deliveries.

Suman Sakhi was launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on September 17, 2025, during his visit to Dhar in Madhya Pradesh, while Suman Panchayat was launched in the state on April 1, 2026.

The initiatives were introduced by 2014-batch IAS officer Dr Saloni Sidana, Director of the National Health Mission, Madhya Pradesh, who is known for introducing innovations in the implementation of public welfare schemes and



THE INITIATIVES WERE INTRODUCED BY 2014-BATCH IAS OFFICER DR SALONI SIDANA, DIRECTOR OF NATIONAL HEALTH MISSION, MP

improving public service delivery. Suman Panchayat is a village-level community participation model under the Centre’s Surakshit Matritva Aashwasan (SUMAN) programme.

It seeks to make maternal and newborn health a shared community responsibility by involving gram panchayats and local residents in awareness activities and discussions on antenatal care, institutional deliveries and postnatal care.

Under the initiative, a gram panchayat recording zero maternal and infant deaths continuously for a year is eligible for a Rs 1

lakh incentive.

The Suman Sakhi chatbot operates round the clock in Hindi, providing pregnant women and their families with information on antenatal care, high-risk pregnancy conditions, childbirth, newborn care and government welfare schemes.

Deputy Chief Minister Rajendra Shukla welcomed the recognition, saying maternal and child health remained a priority for the state government, with a focus on community participation, digital technology and data-driven monitoring.

Both initiatives have also been included in the SUMAN Roadmap 2030 guidelines issued by the Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, which targets zero maternal deaths, zero deaths among children under five, elimination of measles and rubella, universal institutional deliveries and timely childhood immunisation.

Briefs

Punjab: 181 teachers get promotions

CHANDIGARH:

The Punjab government has promoted 181 teachers, including four Block Primary Education Officers, as Headmasters to fill vacancies and strengthen leadership in government schools under Punjab Sikhya Kranti. Education Minister Harjot Singh Bains said the move would boost career growth and ensure dynamic leadership. Of those promoted, 140 are from the General category, 23 SC, six PwD and eight from the backlog PwD quota.

ED arrests 2 in Hashpe crypto fraud

NEW DELHI: The ED has arrested Imran Basha and Hitesh Kumar in an alleged Hashpe cryptocurrency investment fraud involving around Rs 40 crore. The arrests followed searches at 11 premises in Chennai, Coimbatore and Kolkata on September 1 under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act. The agency alleged that the accused lured investors through a purported cryptocurrency trading platform promising high re-turns, before diverting funds through shell entities and associates. A PMLA court has granted the ED five-day custody of both accused.

Minister: Punjab govt to hike DA of 85K employees from 42 to 60%

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, September 4

Punjab government will raise the Dearness Allowance (DA) of around 85,000 government employees from 42 per cent to 60 per cent, to bring their DA in line with the Central pay pattern, Cabinet minister Aman Arora said on Friday.

The decision covers employees recruited after July 17, 2020, whose basic pay is based on the Central government’s 7th Pay Commission matrix, but whose DA is based on Punjab’s pay pattern.

The move does not cover employees recruited before July 17, 2020, who are paid as per the Punjab Pay Commission’s matrix.

Speaking to media-persons, Arora said the decision was taken by a three-member Cabinet Sub-Committee comprising him, Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema and Social Security Minister Baljit Kaur. The recommendation will now be sent to Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann for final approval, he said.

Arora said the move addresses salary disparity between employees recruited before July 2020, who continue to be governed by Punjab’s historically higher pay structure, and those recruited later under the Central pay pattern, with salaries much lower.

The Commerce minister, said the disparity stems from the change in pay structure for post-July 2020 recruits, approved by the then Punjab Cabinet in December 2020.

“This created two broad categories: existing employees governed by Punjab’s higher pay structure and post-2020 recruits whose entry pay scales are based on the Central government’s 7th CPC pattern,” he added.

“Employees recruited before July 2020 continue to benefit from Punjab’s

higher basic pay scale. Employees recruited post-July 2020 were brought under the Central Pay Scale pattern but continued to receive Punjab’s DA at 42 per cent. This distinction could not be ignored,” Arora said.

He said Punjab government employees have historically drawn substantially higher salaries than their Central government counterparts, with employees in several major cadres receiving 30 per cent to 70 per cent higher salaries under Punjab-specific pay scales.

“However, the situation is different for employees recruited post-July 2020. They do not enjoy the higher Punjab entry pay scales. Therefore, the argument that a lower DA is offset by a substantially higher basic pay is far less applicable to this category,” Arora said.

He said 85,000 employees were recruited in the last six years.

FIRST-OF-ITS-KIND IN COUNTRY

MP pilots ‘barrier-less’ tolling, plans statewide expansion

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA
Bhopal, September 4

Madhya Pradesh has launched the first-of-its-kind barrier-less tolling pilot in the country, allowing vehicles to pass through the Fanda toll plaza on the Bhopal-Dewas road without stopping at a conventional toll barrier.

The initiative, being implemented by the Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation (MPRDC) under the leadership of its Managing Director Bharat Yadav, a 2008-batch IAS officer, seeks to reduce waiting



time, unnecessary braking, fuel consumption and congestion at toll plazas.

Bharat Yadav presented the technology and its implementation

plan to PWD minister Rakesh Singh, explaining how the system combines vehicle identification, classification and automated toll processing to

enable uninterrupted movement through the designated lane.

The minister has also asked officials to use the pilot’s findings to prepare

a roadmap for deploying barrier-less tolling at other suitable toll plazas across Madhya Pradesh.

The SLFF system integrates FASTag/RFID readers, high-resolution Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) cameras, vehicle detection and classification sensors, lane controllers and a transaction processing system. As a vehicle passes through the designated lane, the system identifies and categorises it, calculates the applicable toll and processes payment through the FASTag account.

MD of the Corporation

Bharat Yadav said that the technology is designed to allow vehicles travelling at speeds of up to around 100 kmph to pass through the tolling point without stopping.

By eliminating conventional boom barriers and associated braking, it is expected to make traffic movement more continuous while saving motorists time and fuel.

The pilot is currently operational in one lane at Fanda and will be evaluated on reliability, operational efficiency and commuter convenience, Yadav said.

If successful, MPRDC plans to extend the system to all lanes of the three toll plazas on the Bhopal-Dewas road from January 1, 2027, he said.

The system also provides for unsuccessful or delayed transactions. If a FASTag has insufficient balance, registration details are incorrect, or a technical issue prevents immediate toll collection, an e-challan will be generated.

The outstanding amount must be paid within three days, failing which recovery will be initiated along with the applicable penalty.

EDITORIAL

Black Money Without Borders

The familiar image of black money is rapidly becoming obsolete. Suitcases stuffed with currency, secret vaults and anonymous offshore accounts still exist, but economic crime is increasingly migrating to digital networks that allow money to travel faster, cross borders effortlessly and disappear through layers of transactions. Chief Justice of India Surya Kant recently highlighted the extraordinary scale of illicit financial flows worldwide, drawing attention to estimates that put them at \$4.4 trillion in 2025. For India, the warning is particularly significant. The country's digital payments revolution has transformed everyday commerce and widened financial inclusion, but the same speed, connectivity and technological sophistication that benefit legitimate users can also be exploited by criminals. Black money is no longer merely hidden; increasingly, it is moved, disguised and laundered at digital speed.

India's extraordinary embrace of digital payments has inevitably expanded the terrain available to fraudsters. Criminal networks now exploit mule bank accounts, phishing links, malicious applications, impersonation scams, instant transfers and increasingly sophisticated social engineering to steal and move money before either victims or authorities can react. The notorious "digital arrest" scam illustrates the transformation particularly well. Criminals impersonating police officers, investigators or judges can frighten victims over video calls into transferring their savings without ever physically approaching them. Once transferred, money can rapidly move through multiple accounts, payment systems and jurisdictions. This fundamentally changes the challenge confronting law enforcement. A financial crime that once required physical networks and considerable time can now be executed remotely, at enormous scale and with remarkable speed.

Conventional policing cannot adequately confront this new financial ecosystem. India needs stronger real-time coordination among banks, payment platforms, telecom companies, cybercrime units and enforcement agencies. Artificial intelligence can help identify unusual transaction patterns and networks of mule accounts before stolen money disappears. Banks must improve verification and react faster when suspicious transactions are detected, while telecom operators need stronger mechanisms against fraudulent numbers and impersonation. Cross-border cooperation is equally important because digital money can travel through several jurisdictions within minutes, complicating investigation, asset tracing and recovery. Yet technological capability must not become an excuse for indiscriminate surveillance. Fighting financial crime effectively requires access to data, but such access must remain governed by law, proportionality and institutional accountability.

The larger challenge is preserving public trust in an economy increasingly dependent on digital transactions. Citizens cannot be expected to embrace cashless systems enthusiastically if sophisticated criminals can exploit those systems while enforcement remains trapped in paperwork, jurisdictional silos and slow investigations. Nor should innocent account holders become collateral damage in an aggressive technological crackdown. India needs enforcement that is faster and smarter, but also transparent and accountable. Black money has not disappeared; it has evolved. The state must evolve with it. In an economy where money moves in seconds, financial policing cannot operate at yesterday's speed. The objective should be simple: make digital finance convenient for citizens, difficult for criminals and dangerous for those who believe technology can permanently place illicit wealth beyond the reach of law.

LETTER



letter2editor.mp@gmail.com.

Protect the Aravallis

The Aravallis cannot be protected through narrow definitions based merely on height or terrain. They are living ecosystems connecting forests, water systems and biodiversity. An ecosystem-based definition is essential to prevent vulnerable landscapes from disappearing administratively and becoming available for construction, mining and irreversible degradation.

ROHIT SHARMA,
GURUGRAM

You can also send your comments to The Editor, Millennium Post, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

Danger After the Deluge

As Nepal struggles with catastrophic floods, displaced children face another peril – trafficking, exploitation and criminal networks feeding on disaster

UNSEEN THREAT



OP SINGH

THE WRITER IS FORMER NDRF DG WHO LED INDIA'S RESCUE TEAM DURING 2015 NEPAL EARTHQUAKE

As images of homes swept away, families torn apart and schools damaged by the devastating floods in Nepal continue to dominate television screens, another, far less visible consequence may soon begin to emerge. Beyond the immediate humanitarian catastrophe lies the possibility of an invisible aftershock—the trafficking and exploitation of vulnerable children.

The available evidence is already worrying. According to one estimate, the August 26, 2026 floods have left at least 17,000 children in urgent need of assistance, while displacement and increased movement—particularly around border areas—are heightening the risks of trafficking, exploitation, abuse and gender-based violence. Earlier, research found that 95% of weather-related child displacements in Nepal were caused by floods, with more than 2,36,000 child displacements attributed to weather-related disasters over seven years. There is also a particularly important precedent: after Nepal's 2015 earthquake, trafficking risks increased sufficiently for Nepal Police to establish additional border vigilance, while UNICEF documented the vulnerability created by loss of livelihoods, family separation and displacement.



Every child separated by the floods must be identified and protected

When the floodwaters recede, another danger may begin to move. It is the danger of children being separated from their families, disappearing from official records, being moved across districts and borders and eventually becoming victims of trafficking, forced labour, sexual exploitation, child marriage or other forms of abuse.

The scale of the current disaster is extraordinary. More than 1,200 people have reportedly died and thousands remain missing; entire communities have been destroyed and thousands displaced. Schools have been damaged or destroyed, and many children have lost access to the normal protective environment provided by school, family and community.

The first and perhaps most important trafficking risk is family separation. In a catastrophe in which thousands are dead or

MORE THAN 17,000 CHILDREN ARE ESTIMATED TO REQUIRE URGENT ASSISTANCE FOLLOWING THE FLOODS

missing, children may be found without parents or caregivers. Some parents may themselves be searching for missing relatives. Others may be injured, hospitalised or unable to reach relief centres. At each stage, either at a relief centre or a temporary shelter, the child's identity and whereabouts become progressively harder to establish.

Traffickers rarely present themselves as traffickers. In the aftermath of a disaster, the trafficker may appear as someone offering food, accommodation,

employment, education, medical assistance or help in finding relatives. The 2015 earthquake provides a powerful warning. UNICEF documented how the destruction of livelihoods and the weakening of family and community protection increased children's vulnerability to trafficking and unsafe migration.

Nepal will have to rebuild around 20,000 houses in flood-ravaged areas, as per one report. Reconstruction will create enormous demand for labour. As families lose homes, agricultural land, livestock, shops and other sources of income, children may be pushed into work. Boys may be vulnerable to construction work, transport, workshops, agriculture and other hazardous labour, while girls may face an additional set of risks involving domestic work, sexual exploitation and forced or early marriage. The danger is particularly acute when employment is offered outside the child's home district.

The Indian Dimension

For India, this cannot be viewed simply as a Nepalese child-protection problem. The open and extensive India-Nepal movement corridor creates both legitimate humanitarian mobility and opportunities for traffickers to exploit that mobility.

Historical evidence demonstrates that trafficking from Nepal into India is an established phenomenon. There are many cases in which girls and children have been rescued at Nepal-India borders, and traffickers have been using various methods such as deception, fake employment offers, fake marriages and other forms of coercion. The post-earthquake experience is even more instructive. UNICEF reported that Maiti Nepal's border-control posts recorded an increase of roughly 200-300 trafficking cases in the three months following the 2015 earthquake compared with the preceding three months.

Human trafficking is not merely a crime against an individual. Large-scale trafficking following a disaster can become a governance, border-management and national security concern. It can generate illegal migration networks, forged documentation, corruption at vulnerable points, exploitation networks, organised crime and cross-border criminal linkages. Therefore, India's disaster response to Nepal should have two tracks running simultaneously—humanitarian assistance in saving lives and providing food, shelter and medical care, and protective security in preventing children and vulnerable persons from disappearing into criminal networks.

The floods may wash away homes and roads. Traffickers can exploit the resulting vacuum to wash away identities, childhoods and futures. Let every child separated by the flood be accounted for before the trafficker can account for him or her.

Views expressed are personal

A Mission Beyond Security

With the recent change, Ram Mandir must now put ordinary devotees at its administrative centre

SACRED DUTY



SIDHARTH MISHRA

THE WRITER IS PRESIDENT, CENTRE FOR REFORMS, DEVELOPMENT & JUSTICE

assurance would descend, as they represented discipline, professionalism, preparedness, impartiality and, above all, a commitment to service.

It is against this background that the appointment of retired Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra as the first Chief Executive Officer of the Ram Mandir Trust assumes significance. The Ram temple is not an ordinary institution. It is the physical culmination of a movement that, for millions, represented faith, civilisational memory and cultural nationalism.

Since the consecration of Ram Lalla in January 2024, forget about the donation controversy, there has been dissatisfaction among pilgrims, increasingly centred on the experience of visiting the temple. The problem, therefore, is not with Ram Lalla. It is with the manner in which the devotee encounters Ram Lalla. That distinction is fundamental to understanding what is expected of Air Marshal Mishra.

The controversy surrounding the temple administration and allegations regarding financial irregularities may occupy political and governmental discourse. But the CEO's responsibility is much larger. His immediate challenge should be to restore the confidence of the ordinary pilgrim in the institution that has been created in the name of Ram.

There is an irony here which should not be missed. In times of crisis, the uniformed services are summoned because the civil administration is perceived to have fallen short. The arrival of the uniformed man creates an expectation that things will be done differently, more systematically, efficiently and without excuses.



Air Marshal Mishra must make pilgrim dignity his defining mission

THE TEMPLE'S TRUE MEASURE LIES IN HOW RESPECTFULLY ORDINARY 'RAM BHAKTS' ARE TREATED

tematically, efficiently and without excuses.

Air Marshal Mishra, therefore, arrives at Ram Mandir carrying more than an administrative designation. He carries the expectations associated with the institution from which he has retired.

The first transformation must be from "suraksha to sewa", that is, from security to service. Security personnel must understand that they are not merely guarding a building. They are facilitating the journey of a devotee towards his deity. That requires training,

discipline and sensitivity.

The complaints about the pilgrimage experience are, in many ways, remarkably mundane. A hot stone pathway in the summer, inadequate arrangements for drinking water, ineffective cooling arrangements, long queues and discourteous responses from security personnel may appear small in isolation. Collectively, however, they communicate something much larger: whether the institution cares for the person standing in the queue.

Air Marshal Mishra can bring to the temple administration the very qualities associated with the armed forces: clear chains of responsibility, punctuality, standard operating procedures, accountability, training, inspection and measurable performance. More importantly, he can bring the culture of institutional responsibility, where a problem is not passed from one desk to another but owned and resolved.

The CEO should ask simple questions: How long does an ordi-

nary devotee have to wait? Is the waiting environment humane? Is drinking water available at every necessary point? Are elderly pilgrims, children and persons with disabilities being adequately assisted? Are toilets clean? Are queues managed intelligently? Are security personnel trained to communicate courteously? Is information available in a simple and accessible manner? Is there a mechanism through which a pilgrim can complain and receive a response?

These are not sophisticated management questions. They are questions of basic dignity. The real test of the Ram Mandir administration, therefore, is not how comfortably a VIP enters the temple. It is how respectfully the ordinary Ram Bhakt standing at the end of a long queue is treated.

The VIP route may provide convenience. The mass route provides legitimacy. Air Marshal Mishra should, therefore, spend time where the ordinary devotee spends it: standing in queues, walking the prescribed pathway, looking for drinking water, seeking directions and experiencing the security arrangements. He should see Ram Lalla, metaphorically speaking, through the eyes of the pilgrim who has no influence, no access and no special privilege.

Air Marshal Mishra's task, therefore, is not simply to run a temple. It is to ensure that an institution born out of extraordinary faith does not become diminished by ordinary administrative indifference. The expectation is simple: "If this is Ram's temple, the devotee should experience Ram's compassion."

Views expressed are personal

News at a glance

Pak rejects allegations of Hindu temple demolition

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan on Friday rejected the allegations that a century-old Hindu temple was deliberately demolished in the country, asserting that its structure was damaged due to torrential rains.

The Hindu temple in question was located in Siraj village of Narowal area of Punjab province. Local people, minority bodies and a political party said a group of religious zealots demolished the temple to include its land in an adjacent seminary. India on Wednesday unequivocally condemned the reported destruction of the temple.

Dozens die in Nigeria after inhaling toxic fumes

ABUJA: At least 37 people died in Nigeria's oil-producing Rivers state as they were trying to steal oil from a loading vessel, an advocacy group said Friday.

The Youths and Environmental Advocacy Centre said the victims were simultaneously siphoning crude products into their boats from an "illegal tapping point" on Thursday. It caused them to inhale toxic fumes at high pressure, leading to their deaths. Many are still missing, according to the report, quoting a network of volunteers.

Israel frees four Lebanese prisoners as part of deal

TYRE: Four prisoners from Lebanon held in Israel were released and handed over to the International Committee of the Red Cross Friday as part of a deal between the two countries. In return, Lebanon agreed to search for the bodies of Jewish Lebanese citizens who went missing during the country's civil war decades ago.

Dozens of Lebanese prisoners are believed to be held in Israeli detention centres, including civilians as well as Hezbollah militants captured during fighting in southern Lebanon.



A burnt car on the side of a road after massive wildfires in the town of Djemaa Beni Habibi, in Algeria on Friday

AP/PTI

Russian drone strikes Ukraine security service headquarters

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kyiv, September 4

A Russian drone struck the headquarters of Ukraine's security service in central Kyiv, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Friday, ahead of diplomatic talks with US officials on ending the war. The air war between Russia and Ukraine has intensified as the conflict stretches toward five years since Moscow's invasion of its neighbour.

Zelenskyy wrote on Telegram that he had spoken with acting security chief Oleksandr Poklad following the strike. The security service headquarters, located close to the historic St. Sophia Cathedral and international hotels, is among the agencies carrying out deep strike operations inside Russian territory.

"The drone was deliberately targeted at the head of the SBU's office in that building. I instructed Poklad to respond appropriately, significantly, and, if possible, in kind to the Russians for this attack," Zelenskyy said.

GOVT PLANS SETTLEMENT RELOCATION

Nepal unveils relief package to help flood-hit businesses

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kathmandu, September 4

Nepal's government has announced a special relief package for businesses hit by the devastating Bhotekoshi floods, offering concessions, loan restructuring and cheaper credit, as authorities began work on relocating settlements destroyed by the disaster.

The measures came as the government stepped up recovery efforts following the devastating floods, which swept away homes, roads and bridges in Nepal on August 26, leaving hundreds dead and thousands missing, with several settlements along the Trishuli riverbanks destroyed.

The Nepal Cabinet on Thursday described the business-related measures as the first phase of its recovery package, The Kathmandu Post newspaper reported.

Businesses whose commercial vehicles, transport equipment, plants, machinery, tools or other equipment were destroyed



An excavator clears mud, sludge, and debris from damaged buildings along the Trishuli River, at Devighat, in Nuwakot district, on Friday

PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The relief measures come as authorities prepare a longer-term plan for communities whose homes and settlements were swept away
- » The August 26 flood reportedly destroyed around 15 settlements across Rasuwa, Nuwakot and DhadingGorkha, 60 from Dhading and 38 from Tahanu

within six months, it said.

Provincial and local governments will also be asked to provide temporary concessions on property and business taxes, building permit fees and other local charges for affected businesses and properties, the report added.

The government has directed Nepal Rastra Bank, the country's central bank, to facilitate restructuring or rescheduling of loans taken by flood-affected borrowers, it said.

beyond repair or swept away will be allowed to import replacements without paying customs duties, the report said.

The concession will also apply to goods on

which customs duties had already been paid but which were destroyed before reaching their destination. Replacement goods will have to be imported through any customs office

Iranian strikes on Jordan test bonds between US



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai, September 4

Jordan, a staunch US ally that hosts American forces in the Mideast, has paid a price for its relationship with Washington, which has made the kingdom's military bases a target of repeat Iranian strikes.

Hundreds of drone and missile attacks have added to other strains on Jordan that include a slumping economy and volatility in the neighbouring West Bank, where Israeli settlers have ramped up attacks on Palestinians.

Despite the risk of more strikes, Jordanian leaders say they are committed to maintaining the relationship after decades of courting deeper security ties with American officials and offering to be a

“WE ARE LIVING THROUGH WAVE AFTER WAVE OF DISRUPTION, WITHOUT PAUSE

reliable partner with the West in a region rocked by conflict. Analysts say the alliance offers Jordan a way to guard against Iran's attempts to destabilise its neighbours.

King Abdullah II of Jordan seemed to acknowledge the need for such alliances last year, when he warned that destabilisation fuelled by the COVID-19 crisis, Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine and multiple Israeli military campaigns in the Middle East could trigger chaos far beyond the region.

Civil rights groups urge halt to South Africa data centres boom amid water, power use

South Africa has seemingly overcome its electricity crisis

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai, September 4

South African civil rights groups are calling for a halt to the construction of additional data centres in the country until the use of scarce water, land and electricity resources has been investigated.

With South Africa positioning itself as Africa's main data hub and US technology companies like Amazon, Microsoft and Equinix increasingly setting up digital infrastructure in the country, civil society organisations have raised the alarm about the lack of transparency around the projects.

The country's rights watchdog, the South African Human Rights Commission, told The Associated Press that it has received over 250 submissions from interested groups after it called for input in May this year.

According to South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, the country hosts 70 per cent of Africa's data centre capacity, and the government has identified this as an opportunity in the global digital economy,



THE COUNTRY'S RECENT MEMORY OF WIDESPREAD POWER CUTS, KNOWN AS 'LOADSHEDDING,' HAS ALSO RAISED CONCERNS ABOUT THE 160 MEGAWATTS OF ELECTRICITY ESTIMATED TO BE REQUIRED TO RUN THE FACILITY

inviting more tech companies to build digital infrastructure in the country.

However, as in other parts of the world, such as the US, where data centres have been increasing rapidly, their long-term environmental and societal impacts are coming under greater scrutiny.

The commission noted that the country had experienced "significant

growth" in the establishment of data centres, cloud infrastructure and related digital systems. "A key issue emerging from the process is precisely the availability, consistency and transparency of information relating to matters such as electricity and water demand, land use, infrastructure requirements, environmental impacts and impacts on

US President Donald Trump

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Washington, September 4

Confronted by an intransigent Iranian government that has refused to back down in the face of a massive military campaign, President Donald Trump appears to have settled on a dual-pronged approach that combines economic pressure with the potential of a devastating escalation in force.

Having launched "Operation Economic Outcast" just last week to try to isolate Iran from its remaining global trade partners, the Trump administration also resumed strikes in recent days, prompting Iranian retaliation that has renewed concerns of an all-out regional war.

However, the combination of already intense

sanctions on Iran and an off-and-on bombing campaign since the war began more than six months ago has not bowed the Iranian leadership and has left the administration struggling to find a way to wind down the conflict.

Tehran has dug in its heels -- as energy prices rise, the global economy roils and poll numbers on the administration's handling of the war dip ahead of November's midterm congressional elections.

Trump said Wednesday that he didn't think the conflict would last "much longer," but he again shrugged off suggestions that its unpopularity and high gasoline prices resulting from Iran's chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz would affect the elections for Republicans.

SOUTHERN RAILWAY				
Palakkad Division				
Sr. Divisional Engineer/Co-ordination/Southern Railway/Palakkad invites E-TENDERS for the following works.				
E - TENDER NOTICE No. PGT/OT/19/2026 dated 03/09/2026				
Sl. No.	Name of Work	Approximate Cash Value in (₹) lakhs	Bid Security Amount (₹)	
1	Provision for track machine siding at Mannanur for a length of 130 Tmtr.	79.90	1,59,800/-	
2	Removal of vegetation, bushes in midsection along side track in between the tracks, side drain, catch water drain cleaning, in Senior Section Engineer/Permanent Way/Kollengode Section for a period of 1 year.	106.06	2,12,100/-	
3	Removal of vegetation, bushes in mid-section along side track, in between the tracks, deweeding, cutting of trees, side drain and catch water drain cleaning in Senior Section Engineer/Permanent Way/Agadippuram section for a period of 1 year.	198.13	3,96,300/-	
4	Removal of vegetation, bushes in mid-section along side track, in between the tracks, deweeding, cutting of trees, side drain and catch water drain cleaning in Senior Section Engineer/Permanent Way/Tirur section for a period of 1 year.	110.36	2,20,700/-	
5	Pollachi-Palakkad section: Widening of cess and Standardization of embankment work at scattered locations between Km 0.000-53.070 (SL).	756.73	15,13,500/-	
6	Palakkad division:- Conducting 3 D scanning of River bed of bridge nos. 924, 943, 1047, 1116, 1130, 1162, 1169, 1201 & 1274 (9 nos) for the year 2026-27.	19.12	38,300/-	
7	Assistant Divisional Engineer/Palakkad section - Provision of 1.80 m wide FOB to prevent trespassing at Km 540/100-200 and 546/300-400.	492.27	9,84,600/-	
8	Assistant Divisional Engineer/Shoranur section- Provision of 1.80 m wide FOB to prevent trespassing at Km 590/600-700 and 628/200-300- 130 kmph route.	482.48	9,65,000/-	
9	Assistant Divisional Engineer/Kannur section- Provision of 1.80 m wide FOB to prevent trespassing at Km 658/300-400, 677/700-800 and 689/800-900-130 kmph route.	722.36	14,44,700/-	
10	Assistant Divisional Engineer/Mangalore section - Provision of 1.80 m wide FOB to prevent trespassing at Km 808/800-900, 828/100-200 and 848/400-410- 130 kmph route.	736.82	14,73,700/-	
Tender closing date on 15.00 hrs		Completion Period in Months		
Sl.No. 1&6 : 25.09.2026		Sl.No. 1,7&8 : Ten		
Sl.No. 2-5 : 06.10.2026		Sl.No. 2-5 : Twelve		
Sl.No. 7-10: 06.10.2026		Sl.No. 6 : Six		
		Sl.No. 9-10 : Eighteen		
1. All the contracts on Works/goods/services will be subject to the new GST Act as applicable from time to time.				
2. Contractors/Suppliers have to register themselves with GST authorities and to furnish the GST registration number in order to process the bills from 01.7.2017 onwards.				
3. For complete details of the above tenders please visit Web site http://www.ireps.gov.in .				
Note: It is the responsibility of the Tenderer to check any corrigendum issued for any correction or modifications uploaded subsequently in website; the same shall be taken in to account while submitting Tender.				
Sr. Divisional Engineer/Co-ord, Southern Railway/Palakkad (For and on behalf of the President of India)				

News at a glance

JSW Energy operational capacity crosses 15 GW mark

NEW DELHI: JSW Energy on Friday said the company's total operational capacity has crossed 15 gigawatt mark, with renewables having 60 per cent share. Of 15,025 megawatt (MW), 9,067 MW is renewable energy — 3,125 MW wind, 2,426 MW solar, 1,735 MW hybrid, and 1,781 MW is hydro power capacity, JSW Energy said in an exchange filing. The thermal portfolio stands at 5,958 MW. The company said it remains on track to meet its green-field capacity addition target of 3 GW for FY2027, having achieved approximately 42 per cent of the target to date.

Manipal Payment IPO to open on Sept 9 at ₹322-339/share

NEW DELHI: Manipal Payment and Identity Solutions Ltd on Friday fixed the price band for its Rs 805-crore Initial Public Offering (IPO) at Rs 322-339 per equity share. The issue will open on September 9 and close on September 11, with anchor bidding on September 8. The IPO comprises a fresh issue of Rs 320 crore and an OFS of up to 1.43 crore shares worth Rs 485 crore by promoter Manipal Technologies. At the upper end, the post-issue market capitalisation will be around Rs 7,858 crore. Its shares are proposed to be listed on BSE and NSE on September 17.

HDFC Bank, Ujjivan SFB begin search for new CEO

NEW DELHI: HDFC Bank and Ujjivan Small Finance Bank have begun scouting for candidates to appoint as their new MD and CEO, while Kotak Mahindra Bank & Fino Payments Bank are reportedly nearing the end of their selection processes. Fino initiated the search after MD and CEO Rishi Gupta was arrested in February over alleged GST law violations. CFO Ketan Merchant was appointed interim head. At Kotak Mahindra Bank, Ashok Vaswani has opted out of an extension beyond his current term ending December 31, 2026, with internal candidates reportedly shortlisted.

Sebi, ESMA sign pact to boost information exchange on CCPs

NEW DELHI: Market regulator Sebi and its European counterpart ESMA have inked a pact to deepen regulatory cooperation and information sharing on central counterparties (CCPs) under the Indian market watchdog's oversight. The pact provides a framework for Sebi and ESMA to cooperate in line with their respective laws and regulations, while enabling ESMA to place reliance on Sebi's regulatory and supervisory activities, according to a statement by the Indian regulator. The MoU was signed by Sebi Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey and ESMA Chair Verena Ross.

DEADLINE FOR APPLICATION SUBMISSION IS SEPT 7, 2026

Govt's ₹37,500 crore scheme to boost coal gasification fails to attract bids

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 4

The government's ambitious Rs 37,500-crore financial incentive scheme for the promotion of coal gasification has found no taker so far, according to sources.

Despite the September 7 deadline, the scheme has received no application from any private or public player to set up projects under the programme, raising concerns over the viability of the coal ministry's push to gasify 75 million tonnes of coal and lignite, sources said.

Unless the deadline of September 7 is over, it would not be possible to state the number of applications since the whole process is online, the coal ministry said in an emailed response.

The ministry has received communication from several industries expressing interest in participating in the scheme, it said.

In a notice, the coal ministry had said that "the Request for Proposal (RFP) dated July 7, 2026, issued under the Rs 37,500 crore financial incentive scheme for promotion of



UNLESS THE DEADLINE OF SEPTEMBER 7 IS OVER, IT WOULD NOT BE POSSIBLE TO STATE THE NUMBER OF APPLICATIONS SINCE THE WHOLE PROCESS IS ONLINE, THE COAL MINISTRY SAID

surface coal/lignite gasification projects, wherein the last date for submission of applications is September 7, 2026."

It is pertinent to inform that given the scale of funds involved in coal gasification projects, the preparation of Pre-Feasibility Reports (PFRs) and project proposals requires time, the ministry said, adding that application rounds are envisaged every two months, providing multiple opportunities for industry participation.

The Union Cabinet

had earlier approved the scheme to promote coal gasification projects, aimed at boosting clean energy production and reducing dependence on forex-guzzling imports of LNG, urea, and methanol, while insulating the country from global price volatility and supply chain disruptions.

The Union Cabinet under the chairmanship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi approved the scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects with a financial

KEY POINTS

- » The ministry has received communication from several industries expressing interest in participating in the scheme, it said
- » It is pertinent to inform that given the scale of funds involved in coal gasification projects, the preparation of PFRs and project proposals requires time, the ministry said
- » India holds one of the world's largest coal reserves of 401 billion tonnes and lignite reserves of 47 billion tonnes. Coal accounts for over 55 % of the country's energy mix

outlay of Rs 37,500 crore.

Coal gasification refers to the process of converting dry fuel into synthetic gas (syngas), which is used as an alternative fuel and helps reduce carbon emissions.

This process supports production of methanol, fertilisers, hydrogen and chemicals, cutting reliance on imports.

The scheme marks a major step towards accelerating the country's coal gasification programme, strengthening energy security, and reducing

dependence on imports of key products such as LNG, urea, ammonia and methanol.

India holds one of the world's largest coal reserves of 401 billion tonnes and lignite reserves of 47 billion tonnes.

Coal accounts for over 55 per cent of the country's energy mix.

Gasification converts coal/lignite into syngas, a versatile feedstock for producing fuels and chemicals domestically, enabling India to substitute high-value imports and insulate itself from global supply disruptions and price volatility.

India's import bill for key substitutable products, such as LNG, urea, ammonium nitrate, ammonia, coking coal, methanol, DME, and others, stood at approximately Rs 2.77 lakh crore in FY2024-25, a vulnerability further exposed by the ongoing geopolitical situation in West Asia.

The incentive builds on the National Coal Gasification Mission (2021) and a Rs 8,500-crore scheme approved in January 2024, under which eight projects worth Rs 6,233 crore are under implementation.

ANI NEWS

New Delhi, September 4

India's manufacturing sector needs to grow at a 13.1 per cent compound annual growth rate (CAGR) to reach \$7.5 trillion by 2047, according to a KPMG report. The target is important for India to achieve its broader goal of becoming a \$30 trillion economy by 2047.

According to the report, if the manufacturing sector continues to grow at the current rate of 7.9 per cent CAGR, it would reach only around \$2.7 trillion by 2047, leaving a gap of about \$4.8 trillion.

The report said manufacturing needs to expand nearly 15 times, from around \$501 billion in 2025 to \$7.5 trillion by 2047. This would require real growth of about 8.4 per cent and nominal annual growth of around 13 per cent.

"The central thesis of this paper is clear: Workforce productivity is India's most underleveraged growth lever," the report said.

An analysis of more than 130 large domestic manufacturing companies found significant differences in performance. Companies with higher productivity recorded more than 50 per cent higher profitability growth and nearly double the market capitalisation growth compared

IF THE MANUFACTURING SECTOR CONTINUES TO GROW AT THE CURRENT RATE OF 7.9% CAGR, IT WOULD REACH ONLY AROUND \$2.7 TRILLION BY 2047

with their industry peers.

The report also found that more than 70 per cent of enterprises need major changes in their operations to meet productivity targets.

It pointed to several hidden factors that reduce productivity, including too many management layers, weak supervision, unclear roles, dependence on informal knowledge, gaps in contract workforce skills and excessive reporting.

"Many factories suffer from a 'productivity illusion': high activity is mistaken for high performance," the report said.

To address these challenges, KPMG suggested a three-pillar approach -- reimagining work, redesigning organisations and remodeling the workforce.

The report said the use of digital systems, artificial intelligence, performance management and organisational changes could help companies achieve productivity gains of 15-30 per cent.

"The next era of manufacturing competitiveness will not be won only by adding more people or assets, but by fundamentally redesigning how work gets done," it said.

The report identified five other key growth drivers for manufacturing -- workforce shifts, greater global integration, investment in production capacity, innovation and technology, and consumption-led growth.

It noted that small and unorganised manufacturing facilities generate less than 20 per cent of the output per worker compared with large firms.

The report also stressed the need to move surplus agricultural workers into manufacturing through better skilling and training. Agriculture continues to account for around 46 per cent of total employment, making workforce transition important for India to benefit from its demographic advantage.

"Unlike scale or demand-led levers, productivity improvements embed permanently into the system, raising output, margins, and competitiveness year after year," the report said.

It added that a sustained 30 per cent improvement in productivity could contribute nearly 35 per cent of India's future manufacturing output.

Dixon Technologies eyes foray into aerospace, defence, medical electronics

AGENCIES

New Delhi, September 4

Dixon Technologies is looking to enter high-value product segments across aerospace, defence, automotive, medical and industrial verticals as part of its next growth phase, Director & CFO Saurabh Gupta said in the FY26 annual report.

The company is identifying high-growth opportunities and developing a capability roadmap covering capital allocation, talent development and strategic partnerships to evolve into a globally competitive manufacturing platform.

For FY27, Dixon plans to scale backward integration investments, deepen its joint venture pipeline in IT hardware, telecom and mobiles, and expand exports. The phased ramp-up of display and camera module facilities is expected to improve margins.

Its camera module business, operated through a 51 per cent stake in Kunshan Q-Tech India, aims to increase capacity from 70 million units to 180-190 million units over the next few years. Dixon is also pursuing a proposed 60:40 joint venture with Taiwan's Gemtek Technology for optical transceivers and targeting enterprise servers and data centre hardware.

Adani Ports to launch dedicated empty container yard at Mundra

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 4

Adani Ports & Special Economic Zone (APSEZ) on Friday said it will start dedicated empty container yard operations at its Mundra Port. The company said the dedicated empty container yard will streamline container handling and improve service for shipping lines and customers.

It added that the initiative will strengthen Mundra's role as a key gateway for India's international trade and support the vision of Viksit Bharat.



According to the statement, on-site operations will strengthen safety, security and regulatory compliance, and faster turnaround and better use of infrastructure will help optimise logistics costs.

"APSEZ is launching a dedicated Empty Container Yard (ECY) with integrated warehousing at Mundra,

offering end-to-end services across the empty container lifecycle, including storage, maintenance, inspection, and seamless movement to exporters and CFSs," it said.

APSEZ, India's largest integrated transport operator, has a 45.5 per cent share of the country's container market as of FY26. Mundra Port alone handles nearly 35 per cent of India's container trade, making it the country's largest container-handling port. Empty container volumes at Mundra are estimated at around 1.6 million TEUs annually.

RBI to conduct ₹7 lakh crore 30-day variable rate reverse repo auction on September 7

The auction will take place on September 7, between 9.30 am and 10.00 am. The reversal of these funds will take place on October 7

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi, September 4

The RBI on Friday said it will conduct a 30-day variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auction for a notified amount of Rs 7 lakh crore on September 7, according to the notification.

The auction will take place on September 7, between 9.30 am and 10.00 am. The reversal of these funds will take place on October 7. "On a review of

the current and evolving liquidity conditions, it has been decided to conduct a Variable Rate Reverse Repo (VRRR) auction on Monday, September 7, 2026," the RBI said in a release.

The excess liquidity in the banking system is estimated to be in surplus of around Rs 10.32 lakh crore as on September 3.

The central bank also said participants will have the option of premature reversal of the amount lent,

including partial reversal, the RBI said.

Requests for premature reversal can be placed through the E-Kuber portal during 0900-1700 hours on working days in Mumbai and must also be intimated by email to the Financial Markets Operations Department.

Settlement of premature reversal will take place at the start of the next working day following the date of the request. Participants

can seek premature reversal at least two working days before the original reversal date.

On the scheduled reversal date, the participant's current account with the RBI will be credited with the principal amount and accrued interest for the lending period, while the securities offered as collateral by the RBI will be debited from the participant's reverse repo constituent SGL account.

NSE gets regulatory nod for ₹30,000 cr IPO, the biggest so far

The SEBI issued an observation letter, effectively a clearance to the exchange to proceed with the IPO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi, September 4

The National Stock Exchange of India Ltd has received regulatory approval for the long-awaited Rs 30,000-crore IPO, which could potentially be the country's biggest-ever yet.

The SEBI issued an observation letter, effectively a clearance to the world's largest derivatives exchange to proceed with the IPO, according to an update on the regulator's website on Friday.

The NSE's offering of 14.89 crore shares will compete alongside Jio Platforms Ltd, billionaire Mukesh Ambani-led conglomerate's digital services arm, for the biggest-ever IPO tag. Jio's offering is estimated to be about Rs 37,700 crore but its timing has not yet been announced.

The NSE IPO will surpass Hyundai Motor India's Rs 27,858.75 crore listing in 2024 as well as LIC of India's Rs 20,557.23 crore offering in 2022. It will also dwarf Paytm's (One97 Communications) Rs 18,300

CLOSER LOOK

- » Bankers tracking the deal expect shares to be priced around Rs 2,000 apiece, with a formal price band expected to be announced around September 11
- » NSE's offering of 14.89 cr shares will compete alongside Jio Platforms, for biggest-ever IPO tag. Jio's offering is estimated to be about Rs 37,700 cr but its timing has not yet been announced

crore (2021), Tata Capital's Rs 15,511.87 crore (2025) and Coal India's Rs 15,200 crore (2010) listing.

The exchange is expected to announce the IPO price band and other key details next week. The public issue is likely to be

launched on September 15 with the exchange targeting a listing on September 24-25, sources close to the development said. The listing is targeted before the Pitru Paksha period begins on September 26.

The IPO, which will see

light after nearly a decade of regulatory delays, will place NSE among India's 10 most valuable companies by market capitalisation.

NSE, whose listing plan has been held up since 2016 by regulatory scrutiny and legacy legal issues, had filed its draft red herring prospectus with SEBI on June 17.

This week the Supreme Court dismissed SEBI's appeals in the long-running NSE co-location and dark-fibre cases - the governance disputes that had stalled the exchange's list-

ing ambitions for nearly a decade.

NSE dominates the country's equity derivatives market and is the world's busiest derivatives exchange by contracts traded, while also operating the benchmark Nifty 50 index.

The proposed IPO will comprise an offer for sale by existing shareholders, allowing them to monetise their stakes without bringing fresh capital into the exchange.

The offering, structured entirely as an offer for sale

of up to 14.89 crore shares - roughly 6 per cent of NSE's paid-up capital - is expected to raise close to Rs 30,000 crore. Bankers tracking the deal expect shares to be priced around Rs 2,000 apiece, in line with where the stock has been trading in the pre-listing grey market, with a formal price band expected to be announced around September 11.

Because the issue is entirely an offer for sale, proceeds will flow to selling shareholders rather than to the exchange itself.

TO DRIVE ENERGY, INDUSTRIAL TRANSFORMATION

Govt urges industry to lead skilling push under ₹60,000 crore PM-SETU

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 4

The government has urged industry to take a leading role in transforming the country's skilling landscape through the ambitious Rs 60,000 crore PM-SETU initiative to drive India's energy and industrial transformation.

The Pradhan Mantri Skilling and Employability Transformation through Upgraded ITIs (PM-SETU) scheme envisages enhancing the overall quality and relevance of vocational training with upgraded labs, machines, and industry-aligned curriculum in the country.

Speaking on the concluding day of Bharat Electricity 2026, co-located with POWERGEN India and Indian Utility Week on Thursday, Debashree Mukherjee, Secretary, Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE), outlined the government's vision for a future-ready workforce equipped to drive India's energy and industrial



transformation.

She noted that industry partners will now have a controlling 51 per cent stake in Section 8 companies managing ITI clusters, with the government and states providing the bulk of funding and industry's 17 per cent share eligible under CSR.

This model puts curriculum design, technology adoption, and skill development directly in industry's hands, ensuring our workforce keeps pace with the demands of the energy and manufacturing sectors, Mukherjee added.

She also cited Arcelor-

Mittal's leadership in the Vizag cluster as a benchmark for transformation.

Organised by The Energy & Climate Initiatives Society (ENCIS), Bharat Electricity, POWERGEN India & Indian Utility Week 2026 concluded on Thursday, bringing together over 15,000 professionals, 250 exhibitors, and 150 global thought leaders from over 40 countries.

The event highlighted India's energy transition, next-generation utility solutions, and the critical importance of workforce development and collaborative innovation to power

KEY POINTS

» The PM-SETU scheme envisages enhancing the overall quality and relevance of vocational training with upgraded labs, machines, and industry-aligned curriculum in the country

» 'Industry partners will now have a controlling 51 per cent stake in Section 8 companies managing ITI clusters'

the nation's future.

Mukherjee further called on industry to move from recruiters to co-creators, urging participation in curriculum development and investment in trainers and infrastructure.

She announced a national registry of centres of excellence in skilling and encouraged sector skill councils and industry to become awarding bodies under NCVET for faster rollout of industry-relevant courses.

"We are also expanding apprenticeships, with co-funding, especially for MSMEs," she added.

Inviting broad participation, she concluded, "Tell us your future skill needs, shape our ITIs, and help build a workforce ready for India's energy transition."

Tanushree Bhowmik, WePOWER Coordinator, The World Bank, said, "To truly support India's energy transition, we must invest in innovation and our people. An agile and diverse skilling and education system is vital to prepare for the future."

Abhilasha Gaur, CEO, SSC NASSCOM, said, "It's time to move from a job role-based approach to a competency model, combining digital, problem-solving and adaptability, to make the power sector aspirational and attract the next generation of talent."

Dr. Abhinav Jindal, Senior Faculty, Power Management Institute, NTPC Business School, said, "Our hub-and-spoke model, with regional learning institutes and technology-driven training, helps us stay ahead in building a future-ready, sector-wide talent pool."

RBI absorbs ₹6.02L cr via 2 VRRRs amid record high liquidity surplus

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Mumbai, September 4

The RBI on Friday absorbed over Rs 6.02 lakh crore from the banking system through two variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auctions as surplus liquidity remained at a record high.

The central bank received and accepted bids worth Rs 5,41,975 crore in a three-day VRRR auction against the notified amount of Rs 7 lakh crore. The auction was conducted at a cut-off rate of 5.24 per cent.

In another three-day VRRR auction, against a notified amount of Rs 1.5 lakh crore, banks parked Rs 60,419 crore with the RBI, also at 5.24 per cent.

Together, the two operations helped the RBI absorb Rs 6,02,394 crore of surplus liquidity. The RBI has stepped up liquidity absorption operations as the banking system has been flooded with funds following large inflows through the special FCNR(B) deposit scheme.

Currently, liquidity in the banking system is estimated to be in surplus of around Rs 10.32 lakh crore as on September 3, according to the RBI's data. The RBI's special forex measures mobilised \$136.38 billion by August 31, includ-



THE RBI HAS STEPPED UP LIQUIDITY ABSORPTION AS THE BANKING SYSTEM HAS BEEN FLOODED WITH FUNDS FOLLOWING LARGE INFLOWS VIA FCNR(B) DEPOSIT SCHEME

ing \$127.23 billion through FCNR(B) deposits, \$5.26 billion through OFCBs and \$3.89 billion via ECBs, according to the RBI's data.

The FCNR(B) window was closed a month early on August 31 due to the strong response, while the ECB/OFCB facility remains open till December 31 and inflows through these routes are expected to pick up.

The mobilisation brought foreign currency into the banking system, while the subsequent swaps with the RBI provided rupee liquidity to banks. Besides FCNR(B) inflows, month-end government

HIGHLIGHTS

» The central bank received and accepted bids worth Rs 5,41,975 crore in a three-day VRRR auction against the notified amount of Rs 7 lakh crore

» In another three-day VRRR auction, against a notified amount of Rs 1.5 lakh crore, banks parked Rs 60,419 crore with the RBI

» RBI's special forex measures mobilised \$136.38 bn by August 31, including \$127.23 bn via FCNR(B) deposits, \$5.26 bn via OFCBs & \$3.89 bn via ECBs

expenditure, including salaries & pensions payments, also added to liquidity in the banking system.

The higher surplus liquidity in the banking system has pulled down the short-term money market rates in the last few weeks. Currently, the weighted average call money rates are trading at 4.93 per cent, which is 0.32 per cent below the policy rate.

To align with the repo rate, the central bank conducted 32 VRRR auctions between August and so far in September, with maturities ranging from overnight to 14 days.

Briefs

Rupee rises 8 paise to 94.43/dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee appreciated by 8 paise at 94.43 against the US dollar on Friday, supported by optimism over rising foreign inflows and a rise in risk appetite.

At the interbank forex market, the rupee opened at 94.53 and traded in range of 94.43-94.53, before settling for the day at 94.43, up by 8 paise from its previous close.

SAIL output rises to 1.68 MT in Aug

NEW DELHI: Steel Authority of India Ltd (SAIL) on Friday said its crude steel output rose by 8 per cent year-on-year to 1.68 million tonne (MT) in August 2026. In the year-ago month, the output was 1.55 MT, the firm said. Total sales last month stood at 1.87 MT, up 13 per cent over 1.65 MT in the year-ago period. SAIL said it has strengthened its financial position, reducing borrowings by Rs 870 crore from the March 31, 2026 level.

Forex reserves rise \$11.475 bn to fresh all-time high of \$740.8 bn

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai, September 4

India's forex reserves jumped \$11.475 billion to a new all-time high of \$740.803 billion during the week ended August 28, the RBI said on Friday.

In the previous reporting week, the kitty increased \$12.422 billion to a \$729.328, then a record high.

The previous all-time high had stood at \$728.494 billion was attained during the week ended February 27 this year, right before the onset of the Middle East conflict.

The reserves have been increasing since the RBI



announced the concessional forex swap initiatives in June this year amid a sharp depreciation in the local currency. The move has yielded over \$132 billion in new flows.

For the week ended August 28, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, increased by \$9.337 billion to \$600.67 billion, the central bank's

data showed.

Expressed in dollar terms, foreign currency assets include the effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

Value of gold reserves increased \$2.191 billion to \$116.409 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The special drawing rights (SDRs) were down \$43 million at \$18.81 billion, the apex bank said.

India's reserve position with the IMF were also down by \$11 million to \$4.914 billion at the end of the reporting week, according to the apex bank's data.

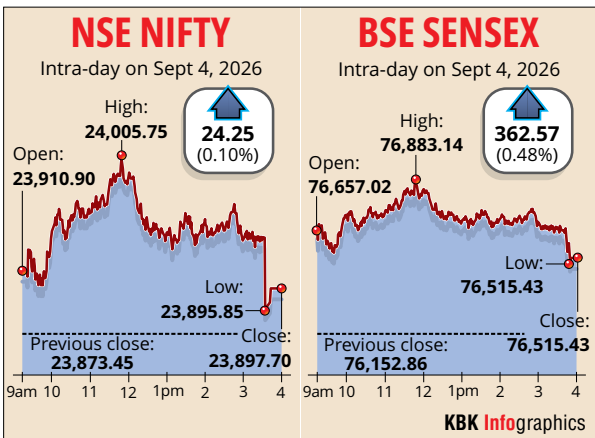
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai, September 4

Benchmark BSE Sensex rebounded by 362 points on Friday, cutting short its four-day losing streak on buying in metal, private banking and oil and gas shares amid gains in global stock markets..

The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 362.57 points, or 0.48 per cent, to settle at 76,515.43 with 20 of its constituents ending higher and 10 with losses.

The broader NSE Nifty, however, saw a modest rise of 24.25 points, or 0.10 per cent, to end at 23,897.70.

Among the Sensex constituents, Tata Steel, Reli-



ance Industries, Bajaj Finance, Trent, Adani Ports, HDFC Bank, Kotak Mahindra Bank, UltraTech Cement, Titan, Mahindra & Mahindra and Hindustan

Unilever were the major gainers.

Bharti Airtel, HCL Technologies, Eternal, Asian Paints, Tata Consultancy Services, Tech Mahindra,

CBIC eases documentation & data norms for bizs under EMI scheme

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 4

The CBIC has "substantially reduced" the data and documentation requirements for businesses that opt for the Eligible Manufacturer Importer (EMI) scheme.

The simplified documentation process for enrolment under the scheme will come into effect from September 15, the CBIC said in a circular. The FY27 Union Budget had introduced a new facilitation measure for trusted manufacturers by enabling

the facility of deferred payment of Customs duty to a new category of importers called EMIs.

Under this, EMIs would be able to clear imported goods without paying Customs duty at the time of clearance. Instead, the applicable duty can be paid on a monthly basis as prescribed under the Deferred Payment of Import Duty Rules, 2016, helping manufacturers better manage cash flows and working capital. The facility is available from April 1, 2026, till March 31, 2028.

In a circular, the CBIC said it has received representations from the trade seeking rationalisation of the data and documentary requirements prescribed for filing applications under the EMI scheme.

Following this, the CBIC in a circular said that the number of documents to be uploaded by an applicant has been reduced from 10 to 3 in the revised application format. Also, the list of data that is required to be submitted has been cut down to ease the process of filing applications.

Goyal: India, Belgium should work together on lab-grown diamonds

AGENCIES
Mumbai, September 4

Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal on Friday suggested that India & Belgium collaborate on lab-grown diamonds, including technology and certification.

Speaking at a high-level dialogue on the India-EU FTA in the presence of Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever, Goyal said gems and jewellery were a key area of complementarity between the two economies. He proposed anchoring the initiative in Antwerp, a major rough-diamond market-

place, and Mumbai and Surat, leading Indian diamond-polishing centres.

Earlier, Wever inaugurated Belgian diamond-grading company HRD Antwerp's expanded facility at Bharat Diamond Bourse, which will increase its research capacity by 30 per cent, according to an official statement.

Wever said the India-EU FTA, signed in January this year, will scrap or reduce tariffs on 95 per cent of Indian and European goods exports, but argued that tariffs on diamonds could be reduced to zero.

He warned against rising protectionism, arbitrary tariffs and market barriers, saying they threaten global economic and geopolitical stability.

On the India-US trade pact, Goyal said India wants preferential market access and tariffs lower than those faced by its competitors. He said talks remain ongoing and there is no deadline for signing the agreement.

Goyal also identified semiconductors, green hydrogen, ports, defence and advanced manufacturing as potential areas for India-Belgium cooperation.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai, September 4

Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever on Friday called for further cuts in import duties on goods traded between India and the European Union, including the possibility of zero tariffs, to spur bilateral trade, particularly in the diamonds sector.

Speaking at the Bharat Diamond Bourse (BDB), Wever said it took two decades for India and the 27-nation EU bloc to reach the "landmark" free trade



RASIKA DUGAL ON BEENA TRIPATHI FROM 'MIRZAPUR' 'SHE FINDS HER WAY TO A COMEBACK'

The actress recalled feeling 'shattered' after Beena Tripathi's assault

Rasika Dugal, who essays the role of Beena Tripathi, has always been one of the most quietly formidable characters in 'Mirzapur'. Unlike the men around her, Beena rarely relies on guns or physical intimidation to assert herself. Instead, she understands the power dynamics inside the Tripathi household, reads the people around her and repeatedly finds ways to reclaim control. With the release of 'Mirzapur: The Movie', Dugal opened up about Beena's darkest chapter, her sexual assault by father-in-law Satyanand Tripathi aka Bauji and the revenge that followed.

For Rasika, understanding Beena's emotional core was never particularly difficult because the charac-



THE BIGGER CHALLENGE WAS DEVELOPING A PHYSICALITY THAT COULD COMMUNICATE BEENA'S CONFIDENCE AND AUTHORITY

ter's motivations were clearly established in the writing. The bigger challenge was developing a physicality that could communicate Beena's confidence and authority.

In a conversation with 'NDTV', Dugal said, "For me, it was never challenging to understand the emotional core of Beena Tripathi. It was on paper. The challenging part was to adapt to her body language. When I first heard the story, my impression was that when Beena enters the room, people should turn around and look at her."

AGENCIES

'MobLand' renewed for season three



British star Tom Hardy will return as fixer Harry da Souza

Hit crime drama series 'MobLand' has been renewed for a third season, announced American streamer 'Paramount+' while also confirming that British star Tom Hardy will return as fixer Harry da Souza amid reports earlier this year of tensions between the actor and the show's producers.

The renewal was announced on Thursday, weeks ahead of the premiere of the second season on September 18. "THE HARRIGANS AREN'T GOING ANYWHERE," 'Paramount+' said on its social media pages while announcing the new season.

ALONG WITH HIM, THE SERIES FEATURES PIERCE BROSNAN AND HELEN MIRREN AS CRIME FAMILY PATRIARCH AND MATRIARCH

Along with Hardy, the series features Pierce Brosnan and Helen Mirren as crime family patriarch and matriarch Conrad and Maeve Harrigan, respectively. The supporting cast includes Paddy Considine, Joanne Froggatt, Lara Pulver, Anson Boon, Jasmine Jobson, Mandeep Dhillon, Geoff Bell, Daniel Betts, Janet McTeer, Jordi Molla and Toby Jones. PTI

DR UMA SHARMA'S 'RAM-SHYAM'

Bringing divine worlds of Ram & Krishna alive

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 4

The worlds of Ram and Krishna came together on stage at the India International Centre on the evening of September 4 as veteran Kathak exponent Dr Uma Sharma and her disciples presented the 22nd edition of their annual Janmashtami production, 'Ram-Shyam'.

Presented as part of 'Krishna Legend', the evening was an exploration of two contrasting yet complementary manifestations of the divine. If Ram embodies 'maryada', duty and the ethical ideal, Krishna represents 'leela', love, wisdom and the freedom of divine expression.

The presentation opened with a screening of 'Shri-Radha', a short film produced by Dr Uma Sharma, followed by her 'Thumri-abhinaya'. Her expressive interpretation brought the poetic and emotional dimensions of the repertoire into sharp focus, demonstrating the continuing relevance of 'abhinaya' as a vehicle for storytelling.

Her disciples subsequently presented excerpts from two of Dr Uma Sharma's dance ballets: 'Ramayan' and 'Maharaas Leela'.



THE EVENT BROUGHT TOGETHER 'ABHINAYA', NARRATIVE AND EXCERPTS FROM HER 'RAMAYAN' AND 'MAHARAAS LEELA' BALLETS

The 'Krishna' episodes included 'Govardhan Leela', 'Makhan Chori Leela' and 'Kaliya Mardan Leela', each using the vocabulary of Kathak to move between narrative, characterisation and devotional expression.

Among the evening's evocative sequences was the depiction of 'Kaliya Mardan', portraying Krishna's confrontation with the serpent who had poisoned the waters and threatened the community. The choreography relied on gesture, rhythm and movement to communicate both the drama of the episode and its underlying symbolism.

The 'Maharaas' sequence brought a more contemplative

dimension to the performance. Drawing from the traditional narrative of Krishna's divine dance with the 'gopis', the presentation evoked the idea of devotion transcending the boundaries of the individual. The multiplicity of Krishna's presence became a metaphor for the intimate and universal nature of the divine.

The presentation also moved into the world of Ram through 'Panchvati Varnan', an excerpt from the 'Ramayan' ballet. Its inclusion gave the evening a broader philosophical frame, placing the disciplined world of Ram alongside the playful and emotionally expansive world of Krishna.

What distinguished 'Ram-Shyam' was its attempt to place Kathak not merely as a performing form, but as a medium through which literature, mythology, devotion and philosophy can continue to be experienced by contemporary audiences.

The evening also witnessed the presence of several distinguished personalities, including Dr Vinay Bharat Ram, Chairman, DCM; Dr Suresh K. Goel, former Director General, ICCR; sitarist Pandit Shubhendra Rao and Odissi exponent Guru Sharon Lowen.

For Dr Uma Sharma, the annual 'Ram-Shyam' presentation has evolved into a continuing artistic dialogue with India's devotional traditions. After 22 editions, the production remains rooted in the classical repertoire while allowing each generation of dancers to rediscover the stories of Ram and Krishna through movement. In bringing Ram and Shyam together, the presentation ultimately offered more than a retelling of familiar episodes. It invited the audience to view the two figures as different expressions of the same spiritual imagination - one defined by 'maryada' and the other by 'leela'.

Boman Irani reveals what sets 'Haiwaan' apart from 'Oppam'

Boman Irani is looking forward to the release of 'Haiwaan', Priyadarshan's upcoming thriller featuring Akshay Kumar and Saif Ali Khan. While the film is based on the premise of the filmmaker's 2016 Malayalam thriller 'Oppam', Boman insists audiences shouldn't expect a straightfor-

ward recreation of the earlier film.

In a conversation with 'India Today', Boman revealed that Priyadarshan deliberately kept the cast of 'Oppam' away while they were preparing for 'Haiwaan'. The actor eventually watched parts of the original on his own but said what he saw convinced him that the new film had been approached independently. "He refused to let us see it. None of us had watched it. But I did watch some of it later, with-

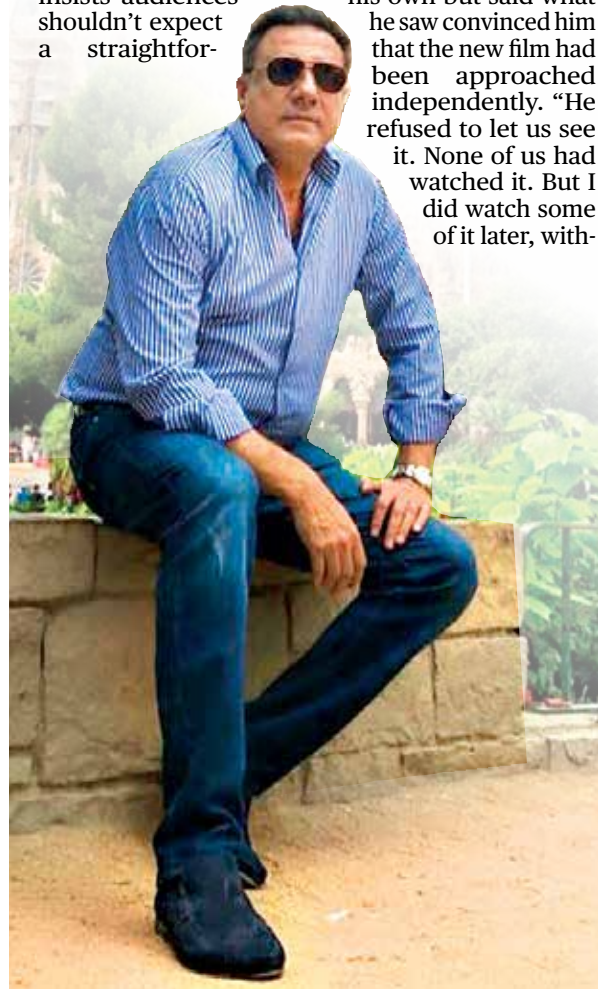
'HAIWAAN' STARS SAIF ALI KHAN AND AKSHAY KUMAR IN LEAD ROLES

out his permission and of course, it's completely different," he said.

Boman also chose not to watch too much of the Malayalam film because he wanted to build his character without being influenced by the earlier performances. "Also, I didn't want to be influenced by it because I might have gone in that direction. But what I understood, plain and simple, is that the man is not cut-and-paste. He isn't thinking, "That worked there so that it will work here". I don't think he depends on that. He likes the premise, the story and the situation and that's what excites him enough to make the film," he added.

Irani also offered insight into the filmmaker's working style, explaining that preparation is essential but doesn't necessarily mean an actor will perform a scene exactly as rehearsed. According to him, Priyadarshan's understanding of the camera can completely alter the approach once the actors reach the set.

AGENCIES



Taapsee says she lost films after Alia's 'Alpha' failure

Pannu is currently promoting her film 'Gandhari'

Taapsee Pannu, who is currently promoting her film 'Gandhari', opened up about how the failure of a female-led film, particularly one with a relatively big budget, can affect the prospects of other women-led projects. In a recent conversation with 'Zoom TV', she shared how the failure of Alia Bhatt-led 'Alpha' affected her own projects.

During the conversation, Taapsee stressed that female-led films are often held to a higher standard, with audiences and investors expecting them to be near-perfect if a substantial amount of



money is invested in them.

"One thing I've noticed and people have been asking me this lately, is that when you put money into a film or mount an action film on a female actor - which isn't a conventional genre for a woman - people ask, 'Why doesn't it work?' If you put money into it, make it a big film and it doesn't work, then how will anyone invest money again? I have only one

question," she said.

Taapsee added, "The big, male-driven film that money is invested in - does it always have an impeccable storyline? Does it always have layers and nuances? Isn't it sometimes just about glamorisation and wow action sequences?"

She pointed out that there is a difference in the standards applied to male- and female-led films and that the failure of a big-budget female-led film can have a direct impact on other actresses who want to headline films.

AGENCIES



TAAPSEE POINTED OUT THAT THERE IS A DIFFERENCE IN THE STANDARDS APPLIED TO MALE- AND FEMALE-LED FILMS